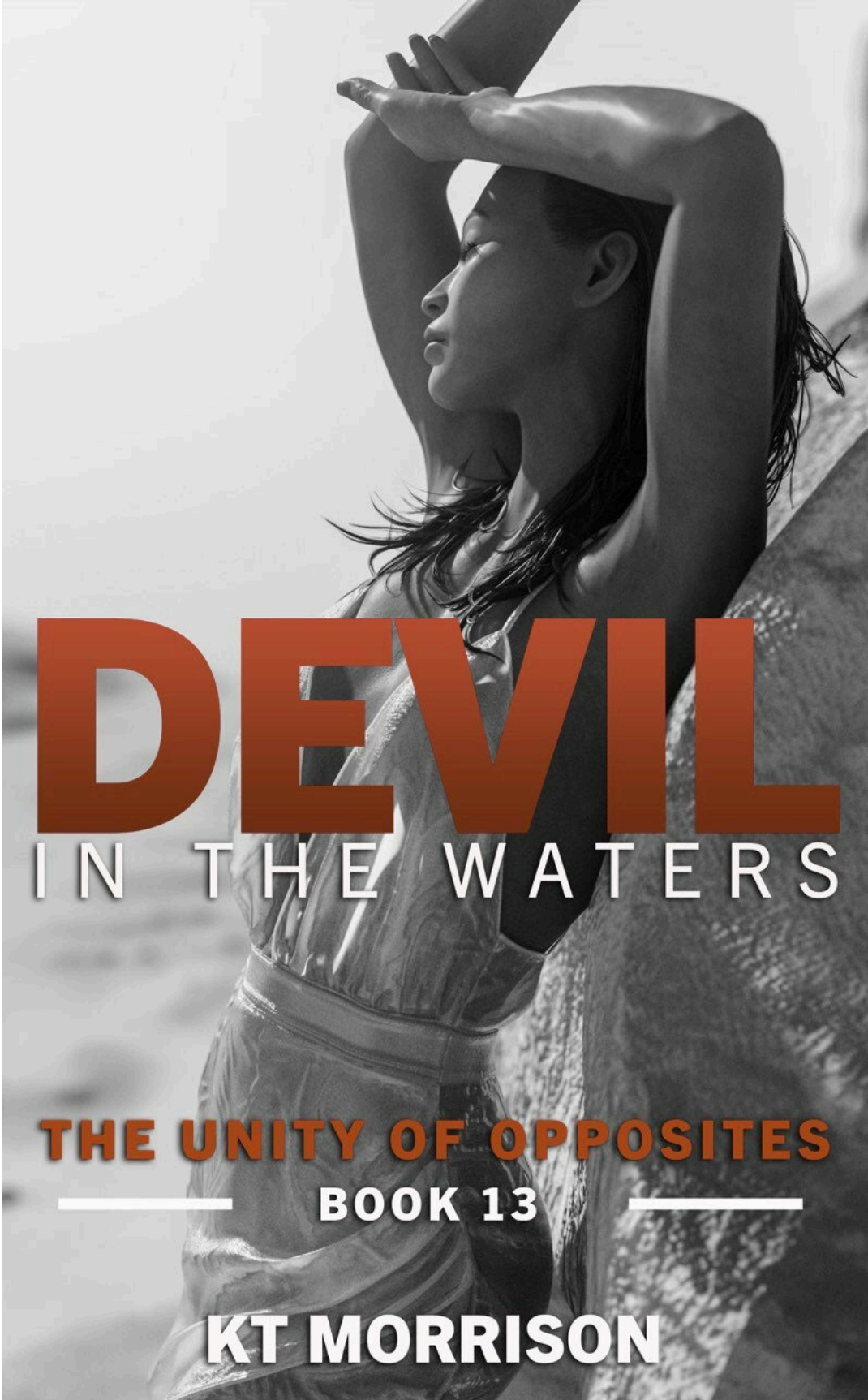




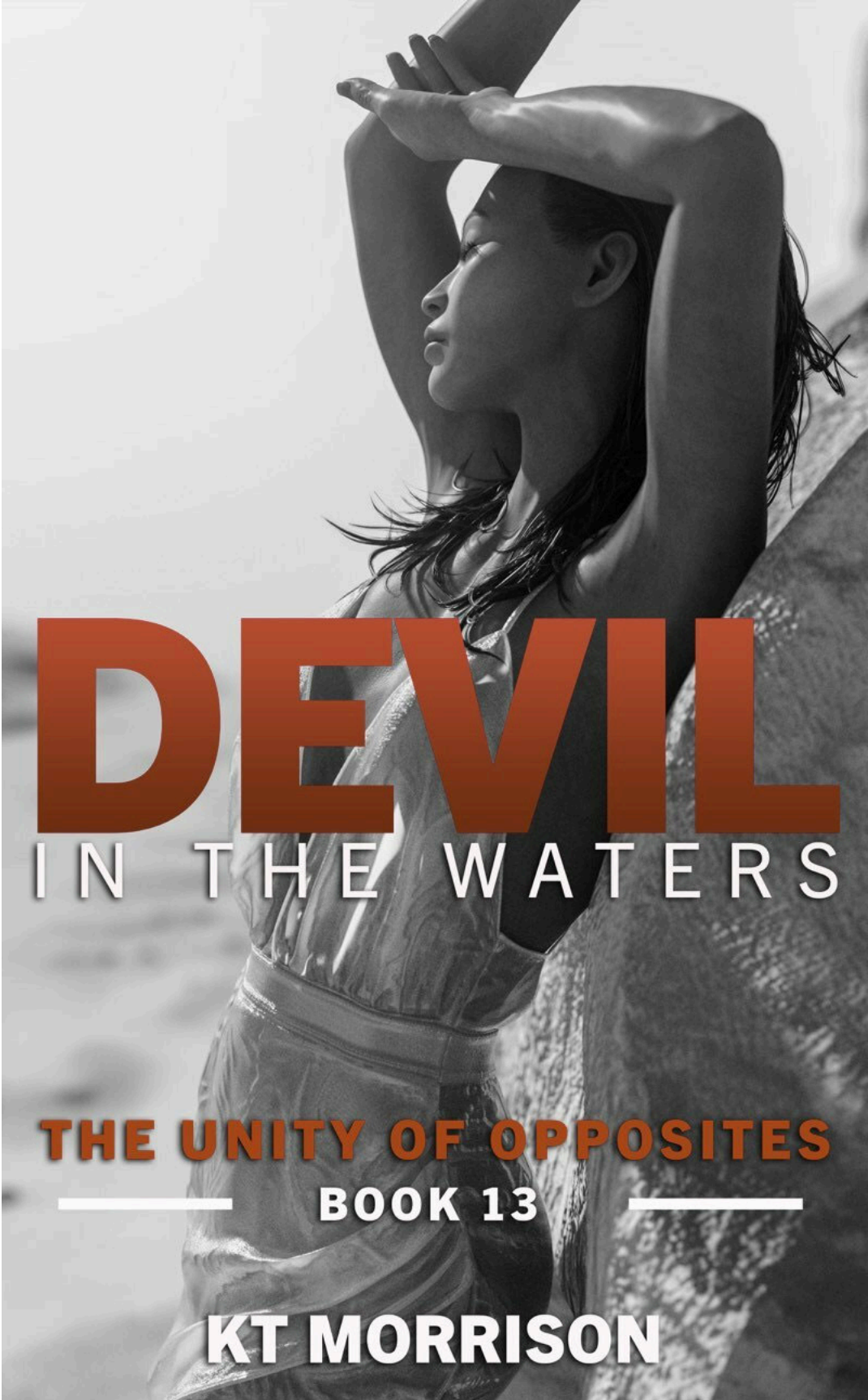
DEVIL

IN THE WATERS

THE UNITY OF OPPOSITES

— BOOK 13 —

KT MORRISON



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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

THE UNITY OF OPPOSITES

A DEVIL IN THE WATERS Novel

30,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

FOREWORD

I know I said there were only going to be 12 books, and then that there would be only 13. The story has been inspiring so much fun on my Patreon that I put up a poll about it, and the results were that the ending to Devil In The Waters should come at an organic pace and not be forced into a book-number timeframe.

So, we're near the end of the series, but there will be more books. I'm not sure how many! But I do know that I am going to take my time and make the ending come in the right way. Many thanks to my supporters on Patreon who make this kind of long form epic possible.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

ktmorrison.com

On my Patreon and on my Ream you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

CHAPTER 1

THOUGHTS THEY CANNOT DEFEND

All he wanted was for Kimmy to tell him the truth. He already knew the answer, whether she fucked Devlin in Cayman; it was screaming in his face. How would she contradict all the lies she displayed on the bed before him, letting Devlin fuck her from behind, putting his cock in her mouth, knowing where she liked Devlin's long dick to touch her, a spot deep inside, where her husband wouldn't find it? Deep secrets.

A voice in his head dared her to lie. Fucking dared her.

"Yeah," she gasped, rocking with Devlin's thrusts. "While you waited. Ah, mm, while you waited for me to c-come back."

He'd been so ready for a deception, had been so accustomed to hearing lies and rolling with them—fucking believing them like some simpering fool—that when the truth sang in his ears, he didn't even know how to react. His stomach soured and rolled over; an awful, sickening feeling. His heart pounded. And though for the first time in a month he felt some relief, he simmered on the edge of a boiling pot of ruin. Tears threatened to burst. A sadness for the man he never wanted to be: the dumb, disadvantaged fool sitting in wait, fooled by an evil enchantress. He felt shame for that visage of himself. That cretin. Not the man he'd ever wanted to be, not the man how he saw himself a man. A victim. A cuckold.

"Did you laugh at me?"

"No, Josh," she gasped. "No."

"How could you not?"

She shook her head no, but Devlin amplified his thrusts, getting the bed squeaking again, robbing Josh of this moment of clarity, kidnapping Kimmy's attention, luring her into his sexual realm.

"I did it," she gasped, fighting the passion, "I did it so I could tell you I did it some day."

"Such fucking bullshit," he muttered.

Devlin hauled up Kimmy's hips, bringing her onto her hands and knees, his big cock never disconnecting, taking her now from behind, like two rutting dogs. Her ass slapped Devlin's hips with each thrust. Balls deep. Kimmy loved Devlin's capabilities. He could hear it in the sound of pleasure she sang and cried. Her nipples jiggled, plump and swollen; Devlin's meaty shaft glistened with evidence of Kimmy's overwhelming desire.

Now Josh clenched his teeth, fighting his own lust, hating the beauty in this brutal grotesquerie. He growled, "You're such a fucking cunt."

Kimmy whined and cried.

Devlin said, "Such a wicked cunt," still pounding her deep and hard. Slap-slap-slap, hips on ass.

Kimmy's cries grew thin, and Devlin buried himself inside her. She orgasmed again, her sounds thin and croaky, like she tried to hide them from him. Soon she shuddered, and when Devlin released her hips, she fell to the bed, her hair hiding her face in a black tangle.

"She just needs it, Josh," Devlin said, panting, stroking his glistening member, Kimmy's copious dew and his own pre-cum dripping from the swollen glans and onto Kimmy's ankle. He admired his handiwork, Josh's wife exhausted, boneless on the bed, her legs shaking. "Look how bad she needs it. Kimmy's a woman who needs to get fucked."



Knees pressed together to keep overwhelming pleasure from taking her over, from spreading like a wildfire from her sexual core and corrupting her mainframe, she struggled to open her eyes and locate Josh. He sat on the chair still, but he'd changed. Anger bloomed in his cheeks and flared in his eyes. Rage. She rubbed her eyes with the heel of a thumb and lifted her head.

She said, "I couldn't help it, Josh," tensing inside, hoping it wasn't too much, hoping it was just enough to bring him to the edge of his sanity without bowling him over the edge and sending him to doom. "I couldn't help it. In Cayman. And I saw it in your eyes, too. I saw how bad you dreamed it. You made me think of it. You put it in my head to do it."

Josh lay a hand over his mouth like a man witnessing a cosmic horror, then drawing the hand down to his chin. "How evil are you?"

She cupped a hand over her own mouth, knowing there was so much more she could say, but that saying it would scare her husband away forever. "More than you know," she said; a fitting answer.

There might be more he wanted to say, but she could read in his eyes he wouldn't say it in front of Devlin. Because begging her for more truth would make him weak. It would show Devlin his most vulnerable emotions. He wouldn't say it here, but he would say it when they were home. She needed him aroused. Needed him entangled. When they went home, they would never talk about what happened in this hotel room ever again. Josh wouldn't ever bring it up.

She needed his dick in the game. With blood on both their hands, all they could do was hide the body together while avoiding a squabble.

She stated it to him clearly: "We're in this together. We've always been."

And she watched her husband wrestle with that nugget. There wasn't much he could say. He wanted the sin to be his own; wanted to watch her with Devlin today so he could own it. But so far, all he'd seemed to attempt was to load this into her pickup bed, make her haul it around. She was guilty and she was wicked, but her transgressions didn't occur in a vacuum.

Josh's features squirmed; he shifted in his chair. There was his reminder. She'd lured Josh's perverse words in Grand Cayman while Devlin prowled beyond the safety of their walls, waiting for his temptations to cement his prey's resolve, bring them out into the light where he could play with them. She knew badness throbbed somewhere in Josh's good heart, and she'd encouraged it closer where she could make out its shape under the surface of the dark waters it swam in.

She got onto her elbows, ran her hair off her face, looked at Josh calm and steady and without judgment. He regarded her as plainly. Devlin remained quiet. Then she slipped off the bed again, Devlin's pleasure payload weakening her knees, clouding her thoughts, going to one knee before her husband once more. She reminded Josh: "You wanted this. You know you did."

Josh's jaw muscles rippled and his brow lowered. He wanted to be mad at her, but he knew he wasn't innocent. And she wanted him to remember that he still wanted it. He wanted it right now, right here in this room, the three of them all together finally, the lies dissolving around them, coming off like blindfolds and restraints.

"So, don't just sit there. You'll regret it if you don't make the most of what brought us here."

Josh chewed his lower lip and looked down, trying to stay stony and in control. She rubbed his knees and stroked her hands up his thighs.

"Own it, Josh. Make this yours. Don't detach yourself."

He shook his head side to side, rolling his eyes up, giving the impression this was all so wrong and he wanted no part of it, and yet he didn't resist, didn't speak the words that would cease her encouragement.

“Josh, baby,” she said, taking the risk of stroking her hands higher, up to his most sensitive and secret part. She stopped her stroking at the top of his thighs and let her hands remain there, waiting. “Join me. It’s not just me in this. It’s always been the two of us. I know you don’t want to believe that, but it’s true.” She showed him how honest she meant it with her eyes, desperate for him to put his toe in the water, test its temperature, realize it wasn’t too hot, wasn’t too cold. In many ways it was perfect.

Her thumb extended, searching out the hump of his cock under his bespoke trousers, knowing it would be rock hard, charged, hammer pulled back, ready to go off. She found him. Found him raging hard. Knew his cock had probably soaked his pants with a steady discharge watching her getting pounded deep and hard, stretched and pleased. The sounds she’d made must have thrilled him to an astounding point. He could fight his lusts as much as he wanted, but he couldn’t hide the truth from her.

“Don’t be ashamed anymore, Josh,” she said, caressing his cock through his pants, her long thumb going up and down, teasingly slow. “You never should have been.” She shook her head, showed him confidence. The muscles in his jaw ceased their rippling. His eyes relaxed, the pupils going hazy with the pleasure she knew he felt right now from the simple action of her thumb. “You wanted me to be wicked.”

Josh’s lips pursed, and he looked aside by a small measure.

“Don’t you want me to be wicked?”

His mouth opened like he would answer, but instead of saying anything, he nodded and closed his mouth again, his lips swollen and pouting. She wanted to kiss him.

“I know you want me to. I can be wicked, Josh,” she said.

Devlin made noise behind her, his body shuffling on the bedding, and she pictured him amused and drawn to this action, wanting to see how wicked she could be, settling on his heels, stroking his dick. She smiled at Josh, snuffled a small chuckle, and showed him deep compassion, looking right

into his eyes until she had his full attention. Her thumb stroked the hump of his erection.

“I want to compare his cock with yours. . . . Is that wicked enough?”

Josh laughed a tight sound of total disbelief and offense, raising his eyebrows and looking away.

“Come on, Josh. Let me be wicked.” She thumbed his cock with more insistence.

Josh remained silent but did nothing to stop her as she moved her hands together to the button on his pants and undid it. “I’m going to take it out,” she said.

Devlin said, “I’ve got a surprise for you.”

She ignored him, staying connected with Josh, but answering over her shoulder: “You do?”

“Show her, Josh.”

Josh rolled his eyes, vexed, shaking his head. He muttered, “Fuck you.”

Devlin shuffled behind her and now she shot a look to see him scooted to sit bedside, right behind her, ready to watch her take Josh’s dick out. If Devlin joined in, it might ruin everything, take Josh’s head right out of the game and enrage him instead of overwhelm him in a cloak of depraved sexual adventure.

She addressed Josh. “What’s the surprise?”

Devlin said, “I dressed him today.”

She frowned, not understanding, not assembling any kind of meaning in Devlin’s cryptic taunt. Josh wore the suit she’d bought him just down the street.

Devlin said, “Unzip him, Kimmy. See how sexy his little dick looks in what he’s wearing under those pants.”

CHAPTER 2

GRAND DISPROPORTION

With his pants unzipped, Josh's bulge pushed through the fly, a humped belly straining against white cotton briefs, stained damp grey with his excitement. She exhaled, long and breathy, the sound of a woman glad to see it. "Fuck, Josh," she said, "you're so hard right now. Look how hard you are."

Devlin sounded disappointed, saying behind her, "You didn't wear them. You said you would."

Josh answered with venom. "No, I didn't."

She said, "Wear what?"

Devlin and Josh answered at the same time, Josh saying, "Never mind," and Devlin saying, "He loves your satin panties."

She rose to stand above Josh, leaning forward, showing him her naked body, caressing his face and kissing his hairline. "I know he does."

"I don't think you know how much he does," Devlin said.

And she said, "I don't think you know how much."

Josh stood up, one hand on his waistband to stop his pants from falling around his ankles. At first, she was frightened he would try to leave, but he stayed with her, leering at Devlin behind her. She put her arms around his waist. Josh said to Devlin, "Are we done here?"

Devlin said, "You tell me."

Josh narrowed his eyes. “Was it everything you hoped it would be?”

“I could ask you the same.”

“What are you going to do now, Devlin? What do you have left? There’s nothing else you can do.” Now Josh gestured toward the bed. “This, what I watched today, was my pleasure—my pleasure more than yours, even.”

“Stop, stop,” she said in a calm and quiet voice. Josh still snarled and Devlin looked back at him, smug. “Josh, we’re not done. You’re not done. I know you’re not done.”

“I’m done,” he said.

“No, baby,” she said, her hands slipping from his back and down the seat of his trousers. She caressed his ass, ran her nails over his underwear-covered cheeks. “Touch me.”

Josh’s features calmed, but he still eyed Devlin. She said, “Look at me. Don’t look at him, look at me.”

Slowly, Josh’s face turned to hers. “Touch me,” she said, and waited.

No smile, no warmth, but Josh’s hands went to the small of her bare back and stayed a long moment. Then his right hand went over her ass and between her legs from behind. She moaned and gasped quick air at his touch. His two fingers squelched through her soaking sex, riffling her eager labia. Her hand traveled as well, from his ass to his front, her palm going over the lovely cotton prominence between his legs. Josh grunted and held his breath, his eyes on hers.

Her other hand swept up to the back of his neck and guided his mouth to her mouth for a long and enduring kiss. Josh was stiff at first, unaccommodating, but he relaxed and his cock flexed under her palm and his lips trembled under hers.

“Sit back,” she said, waltzing with him, guiding him to sit on the edge of the bed. As he obeyed, she knelt between his legs and tugged his pants

until they came down. “And your underwear,” she said.

Josh looked askew at Devlin, who stood silent and patient, watching and waiting.

She said, “Let me see it, Josh.”

Devlin said, “Come on, Josh. Show it to us.”

She was on the verge of scolding Devlin, telling him to back the fuck off before he ruined the whole thing, but Devlin’s provocation didn’t deter Josh like she’d thought it would. Josh’s hands moved to his hips, and his thumbs tucked into the waistband of his briefs. He paused for a moment, then continued, revealing to her, and to his lifetime bully, his own much smaller manhood. He lifted the front of the briefs, then rolled them down the belly of his erection, stopping at his scrotum. His eyes were wide and frightened, his mouth a slim, tense line.

“That’s mine,” she said, running her hands up his thighs, taking hold of the waistband and doing the rest of the labor, struggling his underwear down his thighs, his upright dick wagging back and forth in stiff jags. His shaft and head shone with wet, and a stream of pre-cum fell from the tip to his pubic hair. His cock looked like it might burst; the first two inches were red and shining, his whole shaft scribbled with angry veins. Josh might complain, but in the last two months of their sex lives, her husband had shown performance and hardness like no other time in their life together.

Devlin said, “He likes showing it. He couldn’t wait to parade that little thing around in Cayman.”

“It’s not little,” she said.

Josh showed no fear, no timidity, his smaller cock sticking up where his wife and his bully could see it. It wasn’t a thing to be ashamed of, anyway. But Josh’s eyes weren’t regarding her. Josh looked at Devlin.

Josh said, “You planted those panties on the couch, under the pillow where I would find them.”

She said, “Of course he did. He’s a fucking asshole.”

Devlin laughed in the tune of exasperation. “Your wife was taking forever with this.”

Josh asked, “With what?”

“This. What we’re doing today. What all three of us have wanted from the beginning.”

Josh still stared at Devlin, and she could tell his mind searched for a retort, but he could find none. Josh resisted this so much that even when he’d got what he wanted, he told himself he’d never wanted it to begin with.

“I’m happy,” Devlin said, presenting a hand her way. “Kimmy’s satisfied, and you’re on your back with your little dick up in the air like it’s ready to pop.”

Josh sneered, but his cock flexed, raising up, straining, flexing, slumping back down, a stream of new pre-cum pouring into his pubic hair.

She squeezed Josh’s thighs. “Everybody calm down. Devlin, relax, we’re taking this slow—”

Josh looked at her. “Slow, but you know where you want it to go, don’t you? You’re just like him. You want what he wants.”

With no hesitation, she said, “I don’t want what he wants, Josh. I’m on your side. I’m not on his side—”

“There’s no side to take,” Devlin said. “We’re all in this together.”

Josh reached to pull his pants up, but she held his wrists. “We’re not in this together, Josh, not the three of us. It’s only you and me. Don’t listen to him.”



Josh's eyes traveled from his wife to Devlin and back to Kimmy again. Trying to read them. Trying to decipher their words and their hidden motivations. Devlin was malevolent. And Kimmy was wicked. Selfish, ingratiating, pandering. But she didn't want his suffering—unless it was his own desire to suffer. And—he could see it clearly now—she enjoyed twisting the knife, enjoyed his suffering when it was by her own hand.

Devlin's cock gleamed like a shimmering marine mammal, a bloated sexual porpoise shining with his wife's pleasure on its skin. It sagged under its own mighty weight, wagging side to side with his movements. Two tone. Crooked. Like his wife had described to him in words he'd convinced himself were remediable.

Devlin's demand today, in trade for his appearance in this hotel room, was for his unlucky pawn to arrive wearing Kimmy's panties; the vestment of the humiliated. The subjugated. It was dumb. It was bully language, a blunt prompt from brutish ignorance. And this time it had sounded different from when he'd been coaxed to wear them as an investment into Devlin's photographic evidence of his wife's betrayal.

Kimmy's gaze sought to enjoin him; to fold him over and over like pastry dough. To make her sin indistinguishable from his. But there was more than that in her eyes. Solace. Peace. Charity.

Like folding their sins into one would make them whole. Not apart.

"I don't listen to him," he said.

"Obviously," Devlin said. "Wearing those tighty-whities when I texted you explicit instructions."

Kimmy ignored him, like she had no idea of the reference. His detachment from her barker's pitch, her encouragement to join the sexual funfair she'd

been enjoying this whole summer—laid out in secret rendezvous, legs up, getting the fuckings of a lifetime, squirting all over his bully's giant dick—unnerved her, tensed his wife like a pulled elastic.

If he deflected Kimmy's charity, would he lose her? Did her benevolence come with a catch? If he wasn't her subject, was he anything to her?

"Come on, Josh," Kimmy said, nodding her chin down at a dominant angle that leveled her black and commanding eyes on his. "We're having fun. We're having the fun you and I always talked about."

"Not always," he said. "Only since the summer. Only since Devlin showed up in our lives again." He looked at Devlin and Devlin smiled to one side, not arrogant, only amused.

Kimmy didn't smile. Her eyes stayed on his, steadfast. She spoke in careful and grave words of warning. "Baby, opportunities come to pass. Not to pause. This moment will never come again."

A flicker of regret flashed in his eyes; the idea that she was right, that this moment was fleeting, and he had wanted it. Wanted it bad. But only in theory. Only behind closed doors in the safe confine of his wife's loving embrace; only with his wife constructing forbidden fantasy with dirty words that played out behind his closed eyes.

"Do it," he said to her. "Compare them. You want to see them together."

Kimmy faltered a moment, disturbed by his commitment not seeming to exceed a hundred percent—which was where she expected him to be; where she wanted him to be. He submitted—not to Devlin, but to Kimmy. Naked, exposed, vulnerable. His cock out, shameless, erect. It didn't deter him. This scenario aroused him. It aroused Kimmy. But the path to this moment had been too twisted and too challenging to appreciate the bounty that had launched the journey. Betrayal had deflated the impetus; dumped the ballast that had kept the voyage straight and stable.

If Kimmy wanted it, she could have it. He would donate it to her. She deserved his humiliation. If she could find it.

Kimmy smiled, a sly sort of twisted thing, a compromise between luring and dominating. She said, “You’re not too good for this, Josh. I know you want to play.”

“He started it,” Devlin said, standing beside her now with his fat cock in his hand. “Now he’s thinks he’s above it all.”

Josh raised his eyebrows and tilted up his chin. Let them do their worst.

Devlin stroked his dick, making sure Josh was watching. “Don’t you wish you could fuck her with a cock like this? Do you ever dream about it, making Kimmy come the way you just watched?”

Kimmy said, “Are you going to lie there on your back or are you going to stand up?”

Devlin didn’t let him answer, stepping past Kimmy, saying, “Josh wants to be on his back. He wants to be the girl.” Then he dropped down to the bed, right over Josh, hovering above him with his dick flopping onto Josh’s, batting it twice before resting its heavy weight on Josh’s throbbing erection, before dropping to rest on Josh’s stomach. Devlin’s manhood had never looked huger than lying in direct comparison next to his own. “Isn’t that right, Josh?—satin panties and all.”

It all seemed so familiar; exactly like the dream he’d had where Devlin had come into the tent at Tiffany’s sleepover party at the beginning of the summer; vestigial whispers full of menace. The heat of Devlin’s body, his mass, the talc of his aftershave, his spiritual vibrations.

Two cosmic moments in time touched together like a folded piece of paper.

CHAPTER 3

THE BALANCE OF ARCANE ARITHMETIC

The disparity was shocking and brutal, and she hadn't expected such shame to shine so brightly in her eyes, especially with the grotesqueness of the display. Two cocks, belly to belly, both hard and aroused just for her. These were the endowments of the men she shared her sex with. Two different men with two different sets of needs, two different sets of provision. Unequal in physique and unequal in psyche. Two life forms with masculine instruction, two growing trees that extended canopies to soak up the nutrients, whose shapes and doctrines were formed by the surrounding pressures.

Devlin's cock was a monster that dwarfed the thing that Josh had. Almost twice as long, but it was the girth, the heft, that delivered the most lurid of thrills—seeing her husband humiliated by what her secret lover had fucked her with, over and over, and again and again. That disgusting, meaty thing that hung between Devlin's legs had delivered her indescribable pleasure over the summer and into the fall. And Josh attributed its size and power to her infidelity; that his wife's wickedness was borne on the mighty zeppelin Devlin Stone fucked women with.

And right now, her lover's big cock seeped more excitement from his deep urethra. Devlin loved male dominance—but if he thought Josh drew the domination to himself, Devlin couldn't recognize his own excitement. His own canopy growing to and fro and seeking to claim from thin air the things it needed to survive. Devlin needed Josh, and she'd been the bait. A strange disappointment bothered her. She hadn't expected to ever feel let down by Devlin. Not emotionally. But why would she ever have wanted him for more than the job and the cock? There had never been anything significant between them.

Devlin loomed over Josh the way he sometimes loomed over her. She would lay prostrate on a bed, and Devlin would assume his masculine pose over top of her, displaying his might, his muscle, his overbearing cock size. Dominant. It made Devlin hard as steel to prove himself better. It was pathetic; Josh had never in his life claimed to be anything more than who he was. He was no offence to Devlin Stone. If Devlin sought dominance, why pick on the meek? But then again, he'd used her as bait. Maybe she'd seemed meek, too.

The sight of Devlin's lubricant dripping on Josh's cock skin, rivulets streaming her husband's shaft, drove an erotic spike into her. Josh lay with unamused expression, blank as a mannequin, under Devlin, and Devlin shifted his hips to slide his big slippery cock all over Josh's much smaller one. Seeing the two cocks together was driving her wild; gears turned low in her engine and worked to squash the grapefruit of her sex like a juicer. She could feel the renewed trickle of her arousal.

She inserted herself into the hot spectacle, sitting on the bed beside Josh, getting close to both men, almost face to ear with Devlin, who looked down at Josh like a homoerotic tiger. "It's so hot to see your cocks together," she said, seeking their attention. She slipped a hand between their bodies and ran finger pads over both their slippery shafts, making sure they each got equal time. "He's so big, Josh. Look how much bigger he is than you."

Josh said nothing, but couldn't hide his arousal. His cock twitched and flexed, and he produced a stream of pre-cum. Both men's cocks shone like they'd been dipped balls deep in a jar of oil. To see two straight men endure such strange closeness, and to have their cocks rubbing together this way, got her heart racing. She stretched her grip to hold both shafts together and tried to stroke them. Both men's breaths deepened.

Devlin grumbled, low and lusty, "Kimmy loves my cock, Josh."

She flicked a thumb over his plump, slick cock head, then down to tease Josh's. Josh's eyes stayed on Devlin, talking to her, though, saying, "You know he told me to wear your panties today."

Her teasing thumb slowed, and she regarded Josh. “I’m not surprised,” she said. “ Why would you ever talk to him in the first place?”

Devlin sniggered. “I’m right here.”

“I don’t care if you hear us talk,” she said. “We talk about you a lot.”

“I’m sure you do,” Devlin said. “I heard you two through the window in Cayman. I thought for sure we’d end up in bed like this that night.”

Kimmy ignored Devlin, trying to stay connected with Josh. “Remember when you had them in the car? Outside Hyun’s?”

Devlin said, “The panties?”

“Yeah.”

Devlin sniggered again. “Was he wearing them?”

Kimmy scoffed, exhausted by the juvenile taunts. “He doesn’t wear my panties, Devlin.”

“Oh, yes, he does,” Devlin said, smiling at Josh who still showed no expression. “He wore them to my apartment.”

She removed her hands from their joined penises and stared at Devlin’s profile. This handsome, brutish thug who spoke the language of the bourgeois but was more comfortable in the guttural tones of knuckle dragging troglodytes. How had she ever permitted such a snake to slither beyond her doorway? “The night he found them?”

Devlin said, “The night he came to see your picture.”



It was better out in the open, anyway. What shame was left? He'd been played and teased and tormented and humiliated until shame meant nothing. He could roll shame around on his tongue like a word that's lost its meaning. Shame? Is this shame? What was shame anymore?

Devlin planked over him, him with his pants down, Devlin naked. His wife was just toying with their two members, breathless over the wonderful size disparity. She was naked. He'd watched her have sex with the enemy.

Kimmy now had shrunk to the head of the bed, looking small and thin, but her face stern, her eyes narrowed into black lines. He'd say they were closed but for the flinty light reflecting under her lashes. She said, "What picture?"

She'd asked it before, but could never have figured the truth from the careless overheard taunts.

Devlin said, "What was the picture, Josh? How would you describe it?"

"Get off me," he said, plain and simple.

"Come on," Devlin said, "we're both about ready to pop. I think Kimmy wants to see my massive load coat your whole little dick."

Kimmy said, "Get off him for a second."

Devlin sneered and licked his lower lip, retreating from over top of Josh, slipping to the side to lean next to Kimmy, one elbow down on the bed, his massive round shoulder up to touch his ear.

Kimmy's eyes were on him now. "What picture, Josh?" He'd known her a long time, and though she sounded calm and looked inscrutable, there was a tightness to her tone, a fumble in her pronouncement.

He sighed and sat bedside, got to his feet so he could pull his pants up. The craziest thing was that in all this drama, all this torment, the bullying, the revelations, he was so hard and upright he couldn't do up his fly. He sat

back down in his expensive pants, his erection sticking up out of the fly. “What kind of picture do you think it was, Kimmy?”

Kimmy looked aside to Devlin and Devlin showed the scolded puppy look, unbothered that his summer lover had caught him being a bad boy. And yet, he thought he read more in that look; that it was the expected act of the roguish alpha male, but he didn’t want Kimmy’s scorn nonetheless.

Devlin rolled his head on his muscular shoulder and whispered to her, “I told you that you were taking too long with this. Josh was ready for so much more.”

Kimmy said, “What did you do?”

“He sent me a picture.”

With a new edge to her tone, Kimmy said, slow and measured, “I understand that, Josh, but what was the picture?”

Devlin said, “It was a nice one. Classy.”

Kimmy stared at Devlin, fully inscrutable once more.

Josh let her off the hook. “Your face wasn’t in it, Kimmy.”

Now she steadied her gaze his way. “What was in it, Josh? What was in the picture?”

He took his time answering, glad Devlin didn’t interject. “You with your legs open. That was the picture. Your skirt up, your legs open. Your pussy, Kimmy. You let him take the picture. Were there so many pictures you don’t remember which one it could be?”

Devlin pondered to himself. “I’m not even sure it was you, actually, Kimmy. Could have been anybody.”

Kimmy stayed focussed, eyes blazing black and alive. “You sent my husband a picture?”

Devlin looked at Josh. “I know he got a picture. I’m sure of that. Because he started begging me for more and more.”

Kimmy said to Josh, “You did?”

Devlin said, “How could he not? Whoever was in that picture, she had the prettiest pussy anyone’s ever seen.”

Kimmy stroked her cheeks in slow drags with one long-fingered hand, lost in deep concentration, her eyes now faraway and not laser-beamed on either of them.

Josh said, “It was you, Kimmy. It wasn’t anyone else. It was you and you were on some kind of bags or something, like in a—”

Devlin interrupted. “He didn’t get the pussy part of the picture. I’m not sending that in a text. I’m not stupid.”

Kimmy’s eyes roamed Devlin, from his glossy hair, out of place from hot sex, down his muscular body to his huge cock, still rock hard and ready.

Josh said, “That’s why I went to his apartment. To see this picture. See if it was really you.”

“Kimmy, he was invested. He would have done anything to see it. You underestimate what a player your husband is. He’s into this.”

Kimmy shook her head, eyes distant again. “Why would you do any of this?”

Devlin shrugged his shoulder, head bobbing along with it, saying, “Shine a light on the truth, help you both find the right balance. Sometimes that takes temptation. You know, put things right, let Josh know it was okay to step back, let him know it was okay for you to step forward. Your relationship doesn’t have the right balance. Anyone could see it.”

Kimmy showed no expression at first, then her pretty features tightened into incomprehension. She looked at Josh again. “And he told you to wear my panties?”

Devlin smiled, eagerly waiting to hear Josh admit it.

“Amy told me to,” Josh said. “Amy was the one who texted me. She was the one who told me to wear your panties.”

CHAPTER 4

COINCIDENTIA OPPOSITORUM

Amy's dark specter had loomed large in this endeavor, and she'd known not to trust her, and hadn't let her too close, but hearing Amy's name right now in this room, naked and vulnerable with her husband, and with Devlin, naked and erect and confident, zapped her like a taser. She jumped at the sound of Amy's name.

And then raged. Raged at the prospect Amy could be involved in any of this more than she'd expected, but also raving with a fiery wrath with the hot-poker prompt that Amy had talked to Josh behind her back. There were no rules in this unscrupulous game, but Amy taunting Josh was too corrupt. So corrupt she chastised herself for not anticipating it.

Devlin chuckled and showed off an index of amused expressions, taking a step back and sitting in the chair Josh had been sitting in, dropping into it, heavy, like he was exhausted, his big cock wagging stiff and straight. And upright. So aroused by this bedevilment, by this display of total debauchery and perversity, it was still like a board.

She could see the whole thing now, played out behind her back by those two high school tormentors, Devlin and Amy; lying around and watching Cruel Intentions and scheming their own farce of aristocratic French parlor games of power; of manipulation and of sex, all done in frigid white Canadian suburbs. The idle hands of the bourgeoisie machinate the wickedest games.

She stilled herself, then said, "Amy did what?"

Josh gestured a hand toward Devlin, like presenting him as the devil they both knew. "He knows what I'm talking about. Look at him. I'm right, aren't I?"

Devlin shrugged and feigned a look of incomprehension. She had spent so much time with Devlin that she read through that weak deception immediately. He practically told the truth with the smirk on his face. She struggled to find the right words to say as a surprise cataclysm of betrayal crashed around her. Amy.

A stark feeling of betrayal chilled her; she was in the cold, the others doing things behind her back, without her knowledge, altering her husband's perception. After all the wrongs she had committed behind Josh's back, it was astonishing that she could experience such a reciprocal emotion.

"Amy texted you," she finally said, but Josh ignored her, keeping his gaze fixed on Devlin.

"It was her," Josh said. "She was the one texting me."

Devlin appeared amused, sneering and biting his lower lip, still presenting the facade that he didn't know what Josh was talking about. He entertained them with his antics of his enormous cock, which now lifted and dropped, over and over like it was doing it on its own.

"It wasn't just you," Josh said. "It was Amy, too. Amy texted me, and—"

Kimmy interrupted him. "What did she tell you?"

This time when Josh looked at her, it frightened her. His eyes were alive with a baleful laser-beam focus. His awful gaze set upon her the mantle of responsibility. This was all her doing. Yes, it was Devlin, and yes, it was Amy, but it was her. She shook her head no.

He said, "They're fucking with me. They're fucking with you."

"No one's fucking with anybody, Josh."

"He sent me pictures of you. That's not fucking with me?"

She looked at Devlin, then back at Josh.

Josh continued, “And I went to his apartment like a lost puppy dog looking for an owner, someone who would have the kindness of telling him the truth. All I wanted to know was if it was real, that’s all.”

Devlin grunted, then said, “Then why did you show up wearing those sexy panties? I think you wanted a lot more than a picture.”

Josh looked over at Devlin and her eyes followed as well, both of them wondering how he would see humor in the moment. But Devlin was entertained by his own cock, watching it go up and down, looking bigger than ever, shining, glimmering, a cardinal flesh-obelisk, a singular symbol of the sacred dark and sexual; the wicked-man’s lure that had suckered them both, got them into his fishing basket where he could do what he wanted with them, lay them out in the sunshine and run his dirty blade up their defenseless bellies and bring out their squittering guts.

But that wasn’t the whole truth. It was her. She was the one who was in control. She was the one who’d always sought to preserve Josh. Sought to make him whole, to satisfy him. Sought to protect him.

She stared now at Josh’s profile and felt sympathy and regret. A yawning chasm of regret. There had been so many opportunities to steer away from this final conclusion, but she’d somehow entertained herself into thinking it was the only way out. Even today, out of the blue, Josh presenting sudden salvation to her, she’d thought it was a gift sent from heaven. A way out of this devil’s trap.

She said, “Amy told you to wear my underwear?”

Josh took a moment, still staring at Devlin, looking at Devlin’s dick moving all on its own, looking at the man’s face, then turning to her again. Some of the hatred had dissipated, but she still detected it. It still wounded her.

“She did. And when I showed up...” He shook his head like he didn’t want to continue.

She could only imagine what they’d done to him. The hoops they had made him jump through. All of it done behind her back. Amy, Josh, Devlin,

moving their pieces around where she couldn't see them. She bit her own lips to prevent a string of admonishments and accusations that would come easily off her tongue and would erupt into a fiery tirade. She couldn't. Not now. There was still so much more going on—too much to bask in a satisfying eruption.

All she could come up with was a simple bromide directed at Devlin. “You shouldn't have done that.”

Devlin dropped a hand to cup his scrotum and handle his balls, his face turned up but his eyes looking down at his erect member dancing between his legs, flexing and going through a range of directions like a gear shift. He said, “I don't even know . . . what you're talking about.” Distracted, disinterested, preoccupied. He was still biting his lower lip, and the second before it began, she realized what was happening.

Devlin grunted and squeezed his balls. His stomach muscles flexed like shifting tectonic plates.

He cursed now, a string of half-assembled thoughts that shot blame at her and Josh, hissing and grunting, muttering, ruined it, all that build up, mm, fucking crazy.

And then he was ejaculating. Shooting his voluminous load in front of a husband and wife whom he'd entangled in a poisonous web. And they watched. Husband and wife bore witness to this depraved man's celebration. An autonomous reaction occurring between his legs; a man so aroused by his own devilry, so aroused by the suffering of his prey, that his body could not hold back the physical manifestation of his depraved sexual predation. She watched Devlin come, and she'd seen it before, but she worried for Josh. Josh should not have to see this despicable scene.

Knowing Josh, he would be wounded by Devlin's propulsion, wounded by Devlin's magnificent display that arced two feet in the air, over and over, splats of pearly excitement falling like celebratory confetti. Devlin grunted and flexed, and more and more ropes spat as his cock nodded up and down, sending the semen in arcs. His head rocked back, then jutted forward, veins standing out in his neck and in his arms and shoulders. His chest reddened and his face reddened, and his cock bulged and flexed.

The way Josh watched made her want to cover his eyes.

They were both silent witnesses to Devlin's return to consciousness after his vulgar display of incredible sexual power. He panted, brushed a hand through his hair, his sweaty muscle rippling in a lubricious sheen that aroused her still, despite the horror the man had created.

As he caught his breath, he still spoke, his voice spent, chuckling, saying, "Hoo, no hands, huh. You see that? Fucking incredible."

Josh looked her way, waxen and lost, trying to cast blame on her, showing her his hurt face. Like it was she who'd brought him here and not the other way around. Josh covered his mouth with his hand, his eyes turning down.

"Ruined orgasm. But, wow, I can't believe you guys did that. To me."

She felt sickened by Devlin's vulgarity, by his sole selfish enjoyment of this cruel moment.

Josh stood up, clutching his pants, and it looked like he struggled to swallow. He went around the foot of the bed and headed to the bathroom. Devlin said, "Can you get me a towel, Josh?" Josh closed himself in the bathroom.

Devlin smiled at her. "He's going to jerk off." He admired his own muscular stomach, tracing a finger around the spattered pearly display.

In the bathroom, they heard the sound of the toilet seat lifted and hitting the tank. Then a hollow sound of unproductive retching. Josh was trying to throw up. And she hated that Josh had seen that. Hated that he'd been privy to Devlin's sexuality, knowing it was something his wife had already shared behind his back. And had lied to him about it again and again. The whole idea of the sin as penitence evaporated like water sprinkled on a hot pan. They sat in relative silence, her in tortured guilt, Devlin catching his breath. Sitting naked and unashamed, like a spoiled kid with his mistreated toys scattered around him.

When she couldn't take the silence anymore, she stood as well, slipping off the bed, Devlin's eyes on her right away.

He said, "Don't go to him. You're not his mother."

She said, "I'm getting my clothes."

"Can someone just grab me a towel, please," Devlin said, not to her, but to the room, like a man who thinks the world is out to get him.

Kimmy tracked down her clothing, put on her pants, and zipped them up.

Devlin said, "What, this is over now?" She ignored him. He said, "You need a man, Kimmy. You can't go on with him."

She laughed, averting her eyes from the disgusting big dick, big muscle spectacle on the chair with the sunshine lighting him up. She shoved an arm into her shirt, going braless. "He's my husband," she said, her tone dry with realism. "What are you suggesting? You want to replace him? You want to marry me?"

"No. It was great the way it was—"

She dropped her arms, fists hitting her thighs. "Then why did you wreck it? Why do you think you know better than anyone else?" In the bathroom, the toilet flushed. She shook her head, buttoned her shirt. "I told you never to mess with him and you couldn't help yourself. I've never seen you harder than today. Josh turns you on more than I do. Why don't you have an affair with him?"

Devlin smiled to one side, concern on his face, but still no shame. No regret. "It's not like that. Your dude's into this, Kimmy."

"Amy tell you that? She's a psycho. You know that. You said it."

Devlin leaned forward, his cock dropping between his legs and hanging down, going to one side to lean on his calf. "What about everything else we have together, Kimmy? What about Stone—"

The bathroom door clicked then opened and Josh came out, his face drawn and pale, hands in his pockets.

Devlin regarded him, turning up his palms, then reminding Josh: “Hey, Josh —towel?”

Josh drew his hand from his pocket, raised it toward Devlin, pulled back the hammer, and fired.

CHAPTER 5

RECKONING

Devlin reared back and lounged in the chair once more, clapping a hand over his bare chest. “Agh . . . You got me,” he said, smirking the whole while.

Josh raised his hand to his mouth and blew imaginary smoke from the index barrel of his finger pistol, then holstered it back into his pocket. His eyes were long gone, beyond troubled, somewhere past forlorn. But he smirked, too, saying to Devlin, “Some day you will get yours.”

Devlin raised his eyebrows. “I think I ‘got mine’ today, Josh.” Totally naked, totally unabashed, lounging in the padded chair after she’d been dumb enough to fuck him in front of her husband. Penitence.

Josh’s expression right now stole away all the hope and promises he’d offered an hour ago, the two of them alone in the room. She understood, but hated him for it. Betrayal came in many forms. Josh’s sickly face tightened from loose and lost to firm resignation. He was done here—and she couldn’t blame him for that. He said, “You two think you’re so smart, so great. You think you’re better than everyone else.”

Devlin’s eyebrows twisted, and he looked her way. She didn’t meet his gaze, didn’t want to be associated with him right now. “That’s not true,” she said, voice submissive, even nodding her chin down, eyes drifting to the floor.

“You cheated on me. You plotted behind my back.”

“It wasn’t like that.”

Even Devlin said, “It wasn’t like that.”



It was astounding that Devlin believed he could change gears, and trusting Josh would believe him, trust him all over again.

Agreeableness had led him down this dark path. Right from high school. If he'd retaliated against Devlin back then, where would he be now? Not in a hotel room with a finger pistol making empty threats to his wife's lover. He didn't know back then how much it could mean in his future. It had always felt like he was being the bigger man—turning the good-book's “other cheek” and all—but now look where he was.

He regarded his wife, standing here in this sun bright hotel room, freshly fucked good and deep, barefoot in her expensive pants and her crisp white dress shirt with her nipples poking out double tents. Maybe for the first time ever he saw her for what she was. Evil. Manipulative.

He said, “Did you ever love me?”

Kimmy instantly went limp, as if he'd cut half the cable that ran up her spine. All red-eyed and teary, face harrowed, gravely wounded by such a terrible thing her husband could say to her face.

He followed it up right away with a clarifying angle. “I hope I'm not embarrassing you in front of your boyfriend.”

She cupped a long-fingered hand over her mouth, whispering loud enough to hear: “You're just being cruel.”

He said, “Can you get him a fucking towel, please?”

She nodded and walked to the bathroom, pausing right in front of him, her eyes searching for his, but he wouldn't meet her gaze. She said, “I never stopped loving you once. Not even a little.”

He rolled his eyes. “How can I even...?”

Talking to her was ludicrous.

“Josh,” she said, firmly. He looked at her. “Don’t let this situation get away from us. Don’t let him direct the way you think.”

“You’re treacherous,” he said. “Get him a fucking towel, please. I’m sick of looking at him.”

Devlin stood up. “You’re taking this the wrong way, man. It’s not supposed to be like this.”

Was the guy fucking kidding? Standing there naked after he’d fucked Kimmy and Kimmy wanted to see their cocks together? To compare them? With his giant load on his stomach and running down his legs and his deflating donkey dick hanging between his thighs.

He didn’t answer, looked aside, out the window on the adjoining room where Kimmy had set up their pretend appointment for some guy named Benny Chan. Kimmy returned, staying at his side like they were in this together, throwing a towel to Devlin, landing it on the foot of the bed. “And here,” she said, tossing one of the hotel’s fluffy robes to join the towel. “Put it on.”

Devlin held out his hands at his thighs, like he couldn’t believe the direction the afternoon had taken. “There’s still fun to be had.”

Kimmy said, “Just, please, Devlin...”

Devlin swiped up the towel and ran it over his stomach and chest and down his legs, his dick wagging back and forth and making sticky sounds against his thigh flesh.

Josh couldn’t help making a disgusted sound, and he walked into the suite’s sitting room and turned his back on them, hands on the upright of one of the chair’s seat-backs. He hadn’t thrown up in the bathroom, but he’d come so close. He could taste the bile; could smell it in his nose. The non-stop

eruption of his bully's massive load all over his chest and stomach had turned him over. Kimmy had watched Devlin do that before. She'd done it in Cayman while her shit-head heel of a husband sat in a hot tub fantasizing she might be doing that very thing.

He'd pictured it before, or at least things like it, but could never imagine it would be so ugly, so disgusting, when bearing direct witness. How many times had he come inside Kimmy? How many times had he come in her mouth, on her tits? He shook his head in slow, deliberate wags, feeling an unstoppable rising flux of shame and hate and bottomless sorrow. He'd offered Kimmy Chang his heart and every ounce of trust he could scrounge. Kimmy started it. Kimmy never stopped it. She'd coaxed him, encouraged him, lured him to his darkest fantasies so she could entangle him, drown him in her own lust. Kimmy never stuck up for him, never put an end to this. Just let it all happen. A boot forever stomping on his face, and she just watched.

Kimmy called his name, tender and hopeful.

"What?"

"Josh, it wasn't supposed to be like this. You asked me to do this today, and I didn't want to, and I definitely didn't want to hurt you."

"Oh my god," he groaned on a long exhale. He had. He'd asked for it. He'd thought he could be bigger than the crime. Rise above it, walk through the throngs of writhing demons like some anointed noble impervious to harm; cloaked in some kind of righteous armor. He was such a fucking idiot. He couldn't trust Kimmy. He couldn't even trust himself. What was left for him?

"There were good parts to this," Devlin said. "Those good parts were what I wanted. It's what you want, too. Both of you. I don't know why either of you made this so hard."

Devlin was unbelievable, the only one in the room who couldn't see the unsalvageable destruction in the moment. Josh said, "I never wanted this."

“You dreamt about it.”

“Not once, Devlin. Not once.”

“Amy said you told her you did. When you were drunk.”

“You gotta be kidding me. You’re writing fiction now. I never said that to Amy.”

“She said you wanted to watch me mess around with Kimmy, give her what you couldn’t.”

Kimmy’s voice, quiet, but chilled with serious warning: “Devlin, don’t.”

“Josh, you wanted this. You asked for it.”

“No, I didn’t.”

“Sure you did. You put your hand on my cock, remember? Held it in the tent at Tiffany’s.”

Now he turned, saw Devlin’s face in a mask of pleading, but his eyes sparkled with clear malevolence. All he’d hoped he’d only imagined that night at Tiffany’s was real. It was real, and he’d been manipulated that very night, sold a bill of goods he’d never ordered in the first place.

Kimmy looked unsure, onboarding this wild revelation, trying to determine whether it was true her husband had held Devlin’s cock.

Devlin kept up the charade, eyes innocent, still pleading for Josh to understand the situation. “You wanted it for Kimmy. Amy said you told her your dick was a useless little Double-A.”

Kimmy said, “He doesn’t have a small dick, Devlin, Jesus Christ.”

Devlin snuffled an indignant laugh.

“You both need to stop talking about my dick,” Josh said. He turned away from them and put his hands on the seat-back’s crest again, staring at the

table, wanting to leave, knowing he should, but waiting for something. Not knowing what it was, but still standing here and taking it all, just the same.

Devlin said, “You need to go deep for a pregnancy to take.”

Kimmy gasped.

Red heat raced up Josh’s neck and his hearing went to muted cotton. His temples throbbed and his eyes bugged. It was all so clear. It was laid out in front of him from day one, and his passive malaise allowed it all to roll downhill until it picked up too much speed to stop. Kimmy had shared with Devlin the pain of her miscarriage. Had laid in bed with this man with the enormous dick and lamented her closest, most personal loss. Maybe held in his muscular arms. Shared something that big with him. Bigger than the death of her mother. They’d barely talked about it themselves. Just got up one morning done with crying and went back to doing what they did.

His hands went like claws into the padding of the leather office chair and squeezed them in shaking lumps. The chair was one of those big ones; comfy, chrome flashing, four wheels set on four arms and braced with a chrome racer. It was way lighter than he thought, but then again, adrenaline flooded him with hate and rage and revenge.

Rage felt amazing. It felt better than total helplessness, powerlessness—the warm comfort of his everyday environment. Destruction loomed, large and wonderful on the horizon, like a beautiful glowing sunset, like when the asphalt was steaming on a burning day and you could see the waves coming off, hot and sultry. The chair went out of his grip, hurled with surprising force, and he didn’t think he’d ever forget the wonderful snapshot image of Devlin Stone’s face when he saw it coming and realized he wouldn’t be able to get out of the way. It was handsome horror. And, if he saw it right, recognition, like maybe some part of Devlin’s stunted neanderthal brain calculated his own responsibility in summoning the chair down on him at such a vicious and surprising speed.

Kimmy shrieked. The strangest sound Josh had ever heard. Didn’t think he’d ever heard her make a sound like that before. Not once ever in their lives together.

The chair collided with Devlin's upper body, a mangling crash of awkward angles and sharp edges. Devlin managed to put up an arm in time, but one of the wheels landed a wicked knock on Devlin's forehead. Devlin crumpled and turned away, the breath knocked out of him. Down he went, face first, naked under the flapping robe, the belt coming undone. The chair toppled onto the other more comfortable chair where Josh had sat and watched Devlin do things to Kimmy he could never do, all in the name of absolution, bounced off the cushy upholstery and landed on Devlin's back. One of the wheels had knocked off in the prang and it thumped the window hard enough to make it sound like the glass had cracked. It bounced on the carpet and rolled around Devlin's bare feet in a contracted circle before wobbling to a rest.

CHAPTER 6

PROMISES, PROMISES

All she could think, seeing Devlin struggling on his hands and knees, attempting to rise as quickly as he could, was it was the polar opposite of his favorite way of standing: hands on hips, legs shoulder-width apart. A boy posing as a man. Josh had reduced his ill-gathered merit to its truest form.

But she hated seeing it. Hated seeing Devlin harmed. It didn't matter if he deserved it or not.

"Josh," she said, her voice just whisking air, scolding her husband with a sound of disbelief. She still couldn't believe he'd done that. What had he done?

Josh looked proud of his work, standing curled forward, hands balled at his sides, looking for a fight. His face was the color of a fire hydrant.

Devlin stood up, his back to them, staggered one step forward, hand clutched to his face, the other looking to steady himself on the bed frame. He turned, already talking, "All right, all right, cool it, Josh. Jesus, dude. Okay, that was too far. I knew it as soon as I said it." He pulled his hand away and looked for blood on the palm. There was, but not much. His brow above his left eye showed a ragged gash, like a Harry Potter lightning "S". It was a pale yellow in the centre, the "S" itself drawn in blood, and already beginning to bruise out of the perimeter. Below his eye there was another red mark, two lines going left right, two going up down, like a hashtag. Devlin leveled a finger at Josh. "But if you ever try to come at me with a chair again, I will put your fucking lights out for good."

Josh wheeled, and grabbed the back of another chair, his body stretched out, elastic, ready to propel this chair at Devlin even harder than the first. Devlin

put up a hand and drew up a knee to protect his privates. Josh had caught him in his most vulnerable attire, his robe hanging off one shoulder like a sexy pinup model, the flaps open, his big dick shrunken with fright.

Kimmy shouted Josh's name and thrust herself at him, getting between him and Devlin and putting her hands out in the path his next chair-throwing might take.

Josh looked past her at Devlin, nostrils flared like a Pamplona bull, hate in his ever-placid eyes. She could feel rising sorrow for his transformation.

"Don't, Josh," she said, getting her hands around him, grabbing his arms above the elbows. They stayed like that, both hunched over, him holding the chair, her holding his arms. She said, "It's enough. You almost broke the window."

Josh glared at Devlin. "Who gives a fuck about a window? I'll break every fucking window in this room if I want. I'll throw his stupid ass out on the street below if I fucking want."

Devlin laughed at him. "You couldn't do it, you fucking pussy."

"Today I could, you piece of shit. Today I could. I could do it ten times in a row, you want to fucking see?"

Josh's arms were like steel cables in her grip. He was tense and iron, and he would try to do it if she didn't stop him. She hated to see Devlin hurt, but she would die if she saw anything happen to Josh.

Josh pulled his arms from her grip and hauled the chair back again like he would heave it at Devlin.

"Don't. Please, don't, Josh. Let it go. He's a piece of shit. Okay? He's not worth it. He doesn't matter." She stepped into the chair's path, shaking her head, trying to get his attention, trying to break his gaze from shooting hate at Devlin.

Josh stood straighter, his cabled neck relaxing, his face still contorted with rage, heaving breath. He tossed the chair back down on its wheels with a tremendous clatter. “Take his side, Kimmy. Defend that piece of shit. That’s all I expect of you.”

Devlin said, “You’re the piece of shit, Josh. Say it to me without a chair.”

She turned her head over her shoulder. “Shut the fuck up, Devlin.” When she turned back to Josh, he had stepped away, rubbing his brow, walking to the table.

He growled, low and animal, a sound of pain and awful misery. It grew louder, like a wounded beast, almost becoming a howl before he launched himself at the table like a madman, like a mental patient, snarling and yelling, taking both arms in wide sweeping crescents across the table, back and forth, back and forth, clearing it of all the paperwork she’d set out for a man who wouldn’t show to today’s supposed business meeting. Papers scattered, books and binders flopped and bounced, pens skittered; Josh cleared it all, doing it like a symbolic act, dispersing all of his wife’s carefully laid plans like a startled charm of winter finches, sending them flitting up into the sky, away for good.

He never stopped moving, whipping around, finding his jacket, snatching it up, rising from the floor and coming in an abrupt face-to-face with her. She startled and flinched with fright.

He sneered. “Don’t worry, Kimmy. You’re not worth it either.”

Then he stomped past her and ripped open the door. He strode into the hall and disappeared. She was glad the door closed on hydraulics and he wasn’t able to slam it behind him.

In the quiet, dreadful aftermath, all she could hear was the fast beating of her heart.

All her plans had been scattered. All she’d built had been broken. Josh had stomped through her city like Godzilla. The city deserved the destruction. She couldn’t argue that, but it could have been a very fine city. If Devlin

weren't in the room with her, she would have burst into tears. Maybe she was happy for his presence. Surrendering to the painful mourning that cloaked her now would be her doom.

When she stepped toward the door, thinking maybe, just maybe, if she ran to her husband right now she could preserve their marriage, Devlin said behind her, "Don't follow him. You're not his mother."

She turned to watch him walking past the foot of the bed and going into the bathroom. She followed him in. Devlin bent over the sink and splashed his face with cold water. Kimmy looked to the right, to the toilet where her sweet husband had tossed his cookies after she thought she could lure him deeper into sin by comparing his cock with her lover's. Then Devlin self-propelled his cum all over himself, like popping the top on a champagne bottle to celebrate the end of their marriage.

She leaned on the door frame, crossing her arms. "This could have been so much better. This could have been the best thing for Josh, for me. For you, too. But you had to make it weird. Theatrical. You had to try to humiliate him. For no reason. You're going to regret it. You know that, right?"

Devlin scoffed and stood up, face dripping. He bowed his head so she could see the growing knot right on his brow. "You see this shit? You see what he did to me?"

"Why the fuck would you say something like that to my husband?"

"That was too much," he admitted, snatching a towel from a wall-mounted ring. He buried his face in it.

"Too much? Devlin, you have no idea. No idea at all. Amy told you about that?"

Into the towel, he said, "What, the miscarriage? I don't know. Maybe. Somebody did. Not a big secret. One day you're pregnant, one day you're not. You don't have a kid..."

Now it was her considering kneeling before the toilet. She'd slept with this man. "I should have let him throw you out the window."

"He's the one going out the window, Kimberly." He dropped the towel and gave her a macho stare.

"It's not high school anymore, Devlin. You should seek help. Go talk to someone. I'm not trying to insult you or trying to be funny. There is something wrong with you."

"We're building something, Kimmy. We talked about this."

"Not about this. Not about today. No, wait a second. We did. I told you not to ever do something like this."

Devlin licked his lower lip like he tried to detect swelling, eyes shifted to the side. He leaned on the tiled countertop, all glossy black.

She said, "It gets your dick hard to push people around, to manipulate them. You and Amy."

"That Amy stuff was bull shit," he said and tossed the blood-pink towel into the bathtub. "Look, that was a tantrum he threw. He can't hack it right now. It got heated. Why the fuck did you want to put our dicks together, anyway?"

"I didn't see you flinch. You didn't think twice about it."

"He's your husband. You know him better."

"Then why did you allow this to happen? I told you a dozen times to leave it to me. And you spring this on me, here in this hotel room? I'm here for Benny Chan and Josh walks in."

"Like I said, you were taking too long."

"Yeah, and I guess you were right because look how well this worked out. You've got a boulder on your forehead, a broken chair in a Stone LLC booked room, and my marriage is over."

“It’s not over. You’re so dramatic.” He opened the tall glass door of the shower stall and turned the water on, putting his hand under the spray. “We can save this. And trust me, please: your marriage is not over. That guy needs you.”

“He went to you behind my back and you brought him here.”

“By text, Kimmy.”

“He said he went to your apartment.”

Devlin exhaled through pouted lips, found the water a satisfactory temperature and doffed his robe to the floor. He stepped into the stall and got under the spray face first, the water hitting his chest, his face turned up. “Your husband was on the hook. He—”

“You sent him pictures of me. Did it behind my back. Did it with Amy.”

Devlin shook his head no, like she would believe anything this betraying bastard would say or imply ever again in the future.

“Do you realize how badly you fucked things up? Do you know what you’ve done?”

“Kimmy,” Devlin sighed, like it was exasperating having to deal with her when she didn’t see the whole picture the way he did. “It’s almost good that Josh acted this way. He got it out of his system and now we can get down to the way this is going to work.”

Devlin splashed water on his face, then slicked his hair back. “I need you. You need the job. Even better than needing it, you want it. You want it bad. There’s too big a future ahead of us.”

Now she was the one laughing, though nothing was funny anymore, nothing in the world. She waited him for her to look at her, and she said, “Devlin, you’re going to wish you never met me.”

CHAPTER 7

UNHOLY

The lure to stay away from home was strong. She saw why Josh couldn't resist it. Saw why Josh fled to Meyer's and wouldn't tell her where he was. Because it was easy. It was safe. Nothing bad could happen when you avoided the confrontation altogether.

She opened the apartment door, feeling prepared for what she might find. Maybe Josh would have trashed the place; upended their TV, sliced their upholstery with a butcher knife, set her clothes on fire. That could be the worst, so she started there and made her preparations on a down-sliding scale. She knew he was home. He hadn't cut her off from his Find My Phone this time. It was a good sign, but more likely that he just hadn't thought of it yet.

But the apartment looked preserved. Straight ahead, her father's photo of the Lungshan Temple, straight and square, not knocked askew nor smashed on the floor. The TV was off in the living room, but upright and unmarred. First instinct would be relief, but then again, there was still so much to account for, and maybe if the apartment had been trashed she would find Josh exhausted, spent, tossed on the floor and looking for compassion. The Josh she had witnessed in the hotel room was terrifying. But in the best way she could imagine. That Josh didn't take shit from Devlin. Didn't balk. Didn't cower. It was welcome to see, in a strange, sick way, but terrible to think how much he'd been damaged in order for that savage Josh to have no more kindness blocking him from action. She and Devlin had turned him into a cornered, feral animal.

Josh met her in the hallway entrance, the two of them coming together in front of the kitchen pass-through. Josh was still dressed in his suit jacket and pants. He looked better than ever: that new haircut, no longer a boy, but

now a man; his expensive suit she'd cloaked him in; and a wonderful angry wildness in his eyes. Josh was a man possessed with determination. He'd been in their bedroom, had heard her come into the apartment, and strode out to meet her, an argument already on his lips.

He jabbed a finger at her. "You know what I said to myself? To defeat a demon, become a demon. I'll be as stone cold as you are. Nothing will affect me, I said. I had no idea..." He shook his head—not despondent, but bewildered. "No idea at all."

"You certainly became a demon," she said.

"I went in thinking I was a demon, Kimmy. This is what I'm saying. Thinking I could overcome your crimes, rise above them if I somehow donned a mantle of pretend nobility, that if I could be the one in charge, then I could fool myself into thinking I'd always been the one in charge. But, but..."

She slung her purse to the couch. "You can pretend your responsibility was nothing, but it wasn't, Josh—you weren't always in charge, but sometimes you were. Sometimes you made—"

"You can't put this on me. I'm not stupid. You're not smarter than I am. You betrayed me."

She hugged herself, slumping against the counter's high edge and looking down. "I did. I betrayed you. And I regret it, Josh. I..."

Josh walked away. She followed, all the way down the hall, to the right, to the left and into the bedroom. Josh went into the closet and she stood by the corner of the bed. He had suitcases out and was in the process of filling them with her clothing.

"I regret it," she said, a fear rising up now that she might not have this tiger by the tail, that all the worst things she could imagine might come true.

Josh tossed an armful of clothing to the bed. She stepped to block the doorway. He'd hunched, looking for more of her things to toss, but he stood

up now and faced her.

“I said I regret it, Josh. I’m sorry. It never should have happened.”

Josh’s expression didn’t change. He said, “Did I fail you?”

She shook her head. “No. No, you didn’t.”

His eyes flinched, like he was trying to make sense of her answer. “Then do you hate me?”

“I love you, Josh. You’re everything to me.”

He laughed and shook his head. Looked for more things of hers to haul out and cast away. She went to him, afraid to touch him, but knowing she wanted to be close. “I do, Josh. I love you. I never didn’t love you. I never once cared about Devlin. Not even for a minute.”

Josh groaned a creaky Oh my god and rolled his eyes. She said, “What? It’s true, Josh. I swear.”

He shook his head. “You tell yourself—and you tell me—you hate Devlin. But you only do that because it makes what you’ve done more palatable.”

“I know what you’re saying, but I’m not lying, Josh, I’m not.”

He looked at her. “If Devlin behaved himself, if he did what you wanted him to do, if he didn’t fuck it up by taunting me behind your back, tell me this: how deep would I be in your game right now?”

Her shoulders slumped, and she played dumb. “What game?”

“You were gaming me, you were gaming Devlin. If you hate Devlin, then why do you do the same thing to me? And worse. You had a fucking affair with the one guy I hate most in the world.”

“That’s because of you. That’s because it means something to you...”

“What does it mean to me, Kimmy? What the hell does it mean?—it means he’s the worst guy you could fuck behind my back.”

“No, that makes him the best.”

“Oh my god,” he said, stepping away from her like she was toxic. “The best guy you could fuck behind my back? Like, what the fuck are you saying? Like this was good for me?”

“No, Josh, no, that’s not what I mean. Devlin’s a piece of shit, he’s—”

“I know he’s a piece of shit, Kimmy. What the fuck? You don’t need to tell me that. This isn’t some grand revelation. I told you he was a piece of shit. I told you not to take that job. But you . . . You just had to take the fucking job.”

“I did have to take the job, Josh. I took it for us, I—”

“Us? You destroyed us. You destroyed me. How’s that working out for you, this fucking great job for Devlin? Is it working out the way you wanted it? I mean, you had to take it, right?”

She turned and stepped away, giving him space. There was more bad than Josh could ever realize. Terrible things she’d done, not even revealed to him in the hotel room today.

Josh pursued her. “You love it, huh? You love that money, you love that power. You love it so much you’ll fuck the guy who gives it to you behind my back.”

“Devlin doesn’t give me power, Josh, he—”

“Right, he just signs your fucking paychecks. Does he leave them on the dresser after he fucks you?”

She spun and showed him the exact face she would show if she’d slapped him as hard as she wanted to right now. “Devlin doesn’t deserve a single thing he has. He’s a mediocre man with too much time and money in his pockets.”

“Don’t forget that big dick you love.”

“Josh,” she said, her mouth slimmed in a disappointed line, “don’t be so juvenile.”

“You were the one who wanted to see it next to mine.”

She jabbed a finger now. “You’re the one who wanted to see that, Josh. That was you. That was for you.”

“Oh thanks so much, Kimmy. It was amazing. I loved it. Humiliation is just the best.”

“Don’t act like it came out of nowhere, Josh. . . . It was more than that, Josh. You don’t even see it yet. It had to be Devlin. It wouldn’t be anybody else. This is about you.”

“You fucked him to do me some unseen favor?”

She turned away again. “I never should have done it. But once it was done the first time, the rest of it I did for you.”

Josh chuckled and shook his head. “Oh, I see now. I see it. You’re fucking crazy, that’s what it is.”

She spun and showed him venom. “Don’t call me crazy.”

“So explain to me, oh sane one, how the fuck your disgusting—disgusting—affair with a man I hate does me any fucking good?”

“You’re acting like you and I never lay in bed and made all kinds of dirty talk about me and Devlin. You’re acting like all this was my thing, my affair, when it was—”

Josh stepped up, his face close to hers, eyes in dazzling but baleful glory. “You took something that was ours—could have been ours—and you made it your own. You made me suffer and told yourself that was the right thing to do because Josh likes to suffer.” His finger went in her face. “But it was you who told me it was okay to suffer. It was you who told me it was part of

who I am. You were on Josh's side when it suited you. You had to convince me I liked it. You worked to convince me just so you could get away with it."

She pushed his hand away. "No, you like to suffer. I did it because you liked it."

He challenged her, eyes flashing even brighter. "How did I like it?"

"You responded to it," she said. "Tell me you didn't respond to it."

He put up angry hands, outraged. "That means I deserve it? That means the suffering should be real and not pretend."

She narrowed her eyes. "You knew it was real."

He nodded, smug. "Tell yourself that."

"Tell yourself you didn't. I'm not the only liar, Josh."

"You can't stop lying. Even when I offer you reprieve, when I grace you with my absolution, you still can't stop lying. Everything you're saying is pseudo-psych bull shit."

She said, "You don't even see it. Your head is so far up your own selfish ass, you can't see how you deserve any of the blame."

"No, I can't. I didn't fuck your bully."

"Oh, Mr. Innocent," she said, putting up her hands in a weak pose, "I'm just a victim, everybody else is so mean to me, even my wife who dared to try to give me things I only dreamed of."

"More psych bull shit," he said. "You should listen to yourself."

Now she got in his face. "You had me and Devlin bickering over your ownership, like you were the hottest girl in school. Don't you realize that? Don't you realize what you're worth? What you mean to me? Do you have any idea what I went through to make your dreams come true?"

“What you went through? And you’re not crazy? Do you—”

“I know what you went through, Josh,” she said with snide disregard. “Just accept that I know it. You can’t stop telling me about it. Bemoaning how hard your life is. You’re moody, you hide away, you sulk, you go all the way to Rome with your back turned to me. Like a coward.”

“A coward?”

“You never stood on your own two feet and told me what you wanted. You’re just a shy hint-machine typing out cryptic tickets, like a fortune cookie factory. I have to read your intentions, surmise what you want, try to make sense of the random lottery numbers you give me.”

“Isn’t it easy to know what I want? . . . Or how about what I don’t want? Like, maybe you don’t fuck Devlin Stone behind my back. God, the night I told you how Devlin got Rumble to punch me in the stomach and steal my jacket—you were fucking him then. Listening to my story and nodding, coo-cooing and smoothing my hair, saying oh my poor Josh, and then like the next day you’re in his fucking Mercedes sucking his magnificent cock.”

“He’s nothing, Josh.” She held her thumb and finger up, a hair apart. “He’s this. He’s not even half the man you are. Not even half. But you walk around wearing his high school words around your neck like a useless fucking albatross. You’re better than that.”

Now she had his attention. He stared, eyes crazed with fire, but paused, held in place like a mosquito in amber, wanting her words to be true, wanting to believe what she said because he liked so. Much how it sounded.

“You’re the only person in the world I give half a fuck about.”

“Why would you want to hurt me, then?”

“Because you’re weak. You’re small and weak when I know you don’t have to be. All you ever had to do was tell me what you wanted. I thought you did.”

“You thought I wanted you to fuck him? This is madness.”

She gripped his lapels and held him in place, Josh looking like he would flee. “You fucking asked me to do it today, and I did it. I did it for you. Why can’t you see what you have? Why do you always pretend you have to be moral? You’re not better than me, so stop acting like it.”

Josh snarled and walked into her, grabbing her wrists and marching her back on her heels and shoving her onto the bed. She went down and bounced. Josh stood above her, hands clenched into fists, huffing through flared nostrils.

She went up on her elbows. “Are you ready now to act like a man?”

CHAPTER 8

BOREHOLE

Kimmy looked beautiful and perfect laying on the bed strewn with her things he'd thrown there. All of her bull shit luxury goods, all her bourgeois trappings. Her hair was down, but she still wore makeup. She was long and lean and he could see a sliver of her taut midriff where her shirt came untucked from her high-waisted pants.

He said, "I want you out of here. I want all of your shit out of here."

She tossed her hair. "Who's going to make me?"

"I know what you're doing, and you can stick it up your ass."

She laughed. It was a maddening sight, his wife throwing her head back, showing off the white of her teeth against her red lipsticks. Her neck was long and graceful. He wanted to wrap his hands around it, pick her up, and bounce her off every wall in the room. She stopped laughing and steadied her eyes on him. "You can't kick me out of my own home. It's against the law. Why don't you leave? . . . Coward."

"Why are you doing this?"

"Because you're still stuck in a web—"

"It's your fucking web, Kimmy. You weaved it."

She scowled. "Open your eyes, Josh. You got what you wanted. You can't act virtuous now. It's way too late."

"And how about your eyes? What do your eyes see? Or don't see."

“Me? I’m wicked, Josh. I’m terrible. I did awful things to you. I wanted you to want them. I love you. I see clearly.”

“If you see so clearly, tell me what you see. Am I a coward? Am I a moron, a fucking chump who sat in a hot tub waiting for you . . . and you were fucking him while I waited.” His fists shook.

“And I told you I was going to do it,” Kimmy said, defiant.

“Tell me what you see.”

She said, “You’re no fool, Josh. Don’t act like one.”

“I’m acting like a fool? Is that it? Is that what you see?”

“Look in a mirror, Josh. Tell yourself you didn’t know. See if your reflection can keep a straight face or not.”

He chuckled with unbridled menace, shaking his head, licking his lower lip, snorting breath like a taunted bull in the ring. But she was doing this on purpose. Riling him. Angering him. But why? “Why are you doing this? Why are you such a bitch right now after all you’ve done?”

She said, “Do you think you were the only one who was ever bullied? How does it feel to be the only person in the history of the world to have another human push you under, hold your head in the toilet, and flush? Everyone must flock to you, come to your aid. Is that how it is?”

“I expect my wife to respect my truth.”

“Oh god, Josh. Your truth? I knew you in college and you weren’t in social studies. You were about business. We were about making money, making a family.”

“When did that change? When did that fucking change, Kimmy? Maybe around the time you fucked Devlin Stone?”

“I did you a favor.”

His fists disassembled, and he threw up his hands, completely, unambiguously, bewildered. He wished they had this on camera so he could show his friends, let them all hear the unbelievable words his wife conjured. “And I’m not supposed to call you crazy?” He gestured bladed hands her way as he spoke, like trying to get through to a dog or some simpler minded creature, saying, “You don’t make any sense.”

“I saw you throw a chair today, throw it at Devlin. Hit him right in the face.”

His stomach soured at the memory. At the fear of retribution, at the worry some form of law enforcement would knock on his door at any moment and arrest him for assault.

Kimmy said, “You only did it ten years too late.”

Rumble could come after him. Maybe Devlin would think it was funny to have Rumble meet him in the parking lot outside Swanson, punch him in the gut in front of all of his coworkers. Leave him curled on the pavement, heaving in agonal breath.

“He fucking knows he deserved it, too, Josh. He wasn’t even mad when you left.”

“He wasn’t?”

“He knows it.”

The rage returned as Devlin’s words echoed in his mind’s cathedral, unrepeatable words about his ability as a man, a deep core sample into the most ancient and fragile depths of a man’s psyche. “You were with him. You gave him your body. You’re disgusting.”

“He’s disgusting. I’m still me.”

“Who the fuck are you?”

“I protected you, Josh. I worked for you.”

“This is incredible,” he said, bewildered once more. “Who’s going to protect me from you?”

“You don’t need protection from me, Josh. This is what I’m telling you. This is what I’m saying you don’t see. I want you happy. I want you fulfilled. I want you unburdened. I want you to have the kind of sex no one else in this world could ever give to you. Dark sex. The sex you know you want. The sex—”

“I almost threw up in the toilet watching this dark sex you’re gifting me.”

This was his grandest point, and he expected her to crumble at last, to admit defeat and offer no more defense. But she didn’t. She tossed her hair to the other side now, and he could see she knew how good she looked in this light. The way she let her shoulders come up to her ears, the way her eyes teased him with sultry promise; all-knowing sexual delights were hers, and she wanted him to have them.

“Why did you sneak around behind my back? Why did you skulk your way to Devlin’s apartment and conspire with him?”

“I didn’t conspire, Kimmy,” he said, haughty, on the verge of maniacal laughter. “I went there because you would never tell me the truth. I couldn’t trust you to tell me the truth.”

“You went behind my back, Josh. You went behind my back and ruined everything.”

He covered his face with his hands, breathed deep, gripped his brow, smoothed back his hair. “All you ever did was lie.”

“All I ever did was tell you what you wanted to hear.”

“Like how you had an affair?”

“We talked about that, Josh. It made you hard when we talked about it.”

“They were all lies, Kimmy, they—”

“You knew they were true. You’re the liar.”

His hands squeezed into fists again, and he hunched over her, daring her to spew more toxic nonsense. “They were fantasy, Kimmy. You know it.”

“You wanted it to be real.”

He climbed on top of her and she didn’t resist him, didn’t fight him or complain. He straddled her hips, and she was submissive below him. Submissive but not timid, not shy. He said, “You are such a fucking snake.”

She said, “When are you going to admit your part in this?”

He put his hands down by her hands and she fell back to the bed, silky hair tossing on the bedding and over her discarded clothing, and he realized—though he knew it already by instinct—she had him where she wanted him.

“I’ll admit it when you admit it,” he said, face over hers, her narrow eyes gone to black lines, sunlight glinting under her lashes to prove she was watching him.

“I admitted it, Josh. I admit it all. I fucked him. I did it behind your back. I did it before I knew you wanted it. I kept doing it after I knew it turned you on.”

“You humiliated me. You treated me like dirt.”

She cupped his neck on both sides, her long fingers scratching over the nape of his neck, exposed now by the haircut she’d encouraged him to get. “I put you on a pedestal, Josh.”

“You fucked him at the reunion,” he said. “Tell me you didn’t.”

“That’s what you want to hear. You want me to tell you that?”

“You make me so fucking crazy. Just tell me the fucking truth.”

She jutted her chin towards his in the gesture of an alluring kiss. He gripped her wrists and pulled her hands free from his neck. He pinned them on the

bed, holding her arms up above her head. Her eyes were black gems, obsidian jewels of invasive scrutiny; looking in her eyes was like surrendering, letting her shine her flashlight in all your rooms, closets, attics, crawlspaces.

She said, “The sin was my penitence. Unless you’re a liar.”

He kissed her to shut her fucking mouth. Sealed his mouth against hers before more of her endless brood of spiderling lies and obfuscations skittered forth. Kimmy writhed under him in a seductive dance, and he knew he’d sunk himself by kissing her. But if he didn’t kiss her, her words would cloud his thoughts and resolve and render him useless.

Kimmy held his face while he kissed her, and she rose her hips to meet his, their pelvises coming together in urgent need, telling him what she wanted in case he hadn’t figured it out. Was she insatiable? No, she wasn’t. He’d watched Devlin fuck her, finger her, eat her ass. He’d watched her squirm. He’d watched her squirt. Devlin made her come hard. She was sated. Sated, but she wanted more and more. She wanted complete control. He would never give it to her.

Kimmy guided his face back, those invading eyes seeking his. He squinted, turned away from her in anger and disgust. His heart hammered in his chest.

“You hate seeing yourself through my eyes,” Kimmy said. “Hate seeing your reflection in my eyes. When you do, you see yourself, and it scares you.”

He still wouldn’t look at her, despite the urging of her warm hands. “I never wanted this,” he said. “I never did. I never asked for it. Amy put it in my head.”

“You lie, Josh. I’ve seen what it does to you. You’re still lying to yourself.”

“They did this to me. You did this to me.”

“I did it because you wanted it.”

“I don’t want it.”

“Stop lying, Josh. It’s time you stop lying.”

He faced her, jaw clenched, gritting his teeth, hating her and loving her all at once. Wishing things were the way they were before the summer. Before that; before the miscarriage. But in Kimmy’s eyes, he did see his own reflection. Josh Waters pinning her down, hovering over her. Hard as a rock. Josh Waters threw a chair at Devlin fucking Stone today. The thing he should have done so long ago. He did it for this woman. Because of this woman.

“You’re no different than I am, Josh. You’re not better than me. We’re still in this together.”

“I’m not falling for it, Kimmy.”

“You’re all I want in this world, Josh. I’ll give you everything.”

“You’re a liar.”

“You are too. I lie for you. You lie for yourself.”

“Stop it. Stop talking.”

“Fuck me, Josh. I know you’re hard. I can feel it. I’m right here. You’re right here with me. We’re in this together.”

He shut his eyes and bowed his head, put his forehead against hers. Kimmy brought her knees up on either side of his waist. His cock throbbed for her, thinking all he’d seen, how vile it was. The disgusting eruption of her demon lover. His wife wanting to see his cock against Devlin’s. Because you want it, Josh, not me. Devlin got off today. Devlin fucked today and Josh didn’t. Fucking Kimmy would be a victory. He roared and righted himself over top of her, legs over her middle, his wife laid out on the bed. He grabbed her shirt and wrenched the two halves apart. The buttons burst and scattered. She was naked underneath. She was aroused. Her nipples

hard. But her eyes had softened. She really wanted him. She really wanted him to fuck her.

He inched backward, looking to escape. Kimmy sat up, grabbed handfuls of the suit she'd bought him so her boss, her lover, could go out with her husband and humiliate him in front of Rumble. She said, "You know you want this. You know you're lying."

"I never wanted this."

She flopped back onto the bed. He didn't flee. Her chest was bared, her shirt bunched at her arms. Her hands came to her waistband, and he watched those long, beautiful fingers work open the clasp.

"Open yourself, Josh," she whispered. "Open yourself up to the truth."

"From you?"

She ignored him, her long hand finding his upright erection under the pants fabric and palm-stroking his bursting hardness. "I'll tell you everything. No lies. We don't lie anymore."

He dropped down again, his hands going out above her shoulders, their faces close together. "I'll never trust you again."

Kimmy didn't even flinch. "Trust yourself first. Tell yourself you don't want this."

"I don't," he said, adamant.

She tilted up her chin again, her pillowy lips ready for his kiss. Her palm found his cock again. "Fuck me with this little dick, Josh. Fuck me as deep as you can go while I tell you what Devlin felt like so fucking deep inside me."

CHAPTER 9

AMBROSIAL FRAGRANCE

Josh sneered at her. “You think it’s that easy to control me? You have no respect for me at all.”

“Tell me why your dick is so hard then, Josh?” She palmed his cock, wanting him to surrender, needing his resolve broken, needing his passion ignited into a lustful inferno.

“You must be so happy my dick gets hard when you’re so fucking evil. Because you are evil.”

She retreated. Let his dick go, lay back on the bed, and closed her eyes. Josh stayed over her. “I don’t want to control you.”

“You want me to give in, to fuck you, to forget it all and abandon everything you’ve done to me.”

She nodded. “I’m so terrible. What a bad person I am.”

With her eyes closed, it was hard to read Josh, but he said nothing. She listened to him breathe.

“I’m so terrible I’d do anything for you. I’m so terrible I’d do anything to have you back. I’m so fucking terrible, all I want is for us to be together at the end of all of this.”

“And you get everything. You get your affair, you get my absolution... What else do you want? I guess you still want to work for Devlin, too? Want me to believe nothing will ever happen again?”

Now she opened her eyes, tilted down her chin so she could see him. She could spin new tales, give him a sales pitch that would sway him. He wouldn't believe her—or at least, certainly not trust her. And there was so much more bad he would see in her.

“You offered absolution. I would do anything to have it. I showed you. That was a show, Josh. That was a show I put on for you. I know you won't believe me, but I hoped you would like it. I sure didn't.”

“You squirted.”

She clucked her tongue, closed her eyes and let her head drop. “Don't be gross.”

More silence. Then Josh said, “He taught you or something, didn't he? It wasn't me. You made me think it was me.”

“I wanted it to be you.”

“I don't ever want to see you squirt again. That's yours, that's his.”

She scooted back and sat up. “Josh, I don't want to talk about squirting or sick things. Please. Okay? Please, tell me what I can do to make it better. To apologize, to convince you that I hated my time with him.” She rolled her eyes, knowing Josh would only think of the pleasure she'd shown today, the ways her body reacted to Devlin's skills. “You're my husband. I betrayed you, I know. I know it. When I found out some of this turned you on, I used it. I used it to soothe the bad things I did.”

“You used it to keep doing the bad things you did.” Josh's stare was serious.

They looked into each other's eyes for a long while and Josh didn't bend, didn't look away. He was wide awake now. She looked down first. She said, “Do you think I love you? Or do you think that's a lie, too?”

Josh sighed, pulled away, but didn't leave. He sat on the bed beside her, his back facing her.

“I do love you, Josh. How can I prove it?”

He didn't answer, only put his head in his hands. It was a time machine shunt to the awful mire of her trip to Rome. The first time she'd ever thought he might leave her because of something she'd done. Something she knew was wrong, something she couldn't stop herself from doing. She looked at his handsome cheek, his cute ear, the way his new haircut swept around his ear shape. His hands looked good, his neck. He looked nothing like the man she'd married. They'd been kids at their wedding. They didn't think they were kids, but they were. Anyone who could see them now would see the difference.

She said to his buried face, "It was only for the money. Is that what you want to hear?"

He huffed a defeated breath. "Not the first time," he said, looking up and out their bedroom window, his expression sad and lost. Then he regarded her. "When was the first time? What did you do at Tiffany's?"

She looked down. "We didn't have sex."

"Are you lying?"

She shook her head no. "Almost. But no."

He asked her again. "Kimmy, are you lying? Look at me."

She looked up, restraining irritation at his disbelief. "I did not have sex with him at Tiffany's. I almost did."

His eyes narrowed with scrutiny. "Then what did you do?"

"I told you. We fought. I wanted to claw his eyes out. I really don't like him. And then we... I don't know, we, like, ended up messing around."

Josh made a disgusted sound and looked away. "And he didn't get his dick in you?"

Saying no would be so easy. She said, "A little. But not all the way."

"Fuck's sake," Josh hissed, got up and walked to the window.

She said, “We tried, but I didn’t want that to happen. I guess... I guess my body did, but...”

“You know he came into my tent to tell me he did that? Did it right away. I was still drunk. He put his dick in my hand.”

Her mouth slimmed. She’d been so dumb to think she had control over Devlin. Though she had it at one time, he was a deceptive animal who loved trouble.

“He asked me if I could smell your pussy on it.”

Her stomach turned over, knowing how cruel that was, how awful. The torment it would provoke.

“I told myself I’d dreamt it. Kimmy wouldn’t mess around with Devlin. I must have dreamt it. But no, my wife did mess around with him. Messed around with a guy who only fucked her because she was married to me.”

As far as insults went, that one was light and only a fraction of what she deserved. She let it go.

She said, “They got us.”

“What do you mean?”

She said, “It was both of them. Devlin and Amy.”

Josh shrugged, eyes still cast out over the autumn tree line beyond their apartment. “Maybe.”

“You said it was Amy who texted you.”

“I don’t know it was.”

“I believe it. You’re not the only one who was bullied.”

He regarded her over his shoulder, eyes pinched with disdain. “When? This summer?”

“In high school, Josh.”

“Amy bullied you?”

She didn't like the tone of his voice, the arrogant questioning, as if she was making this up. Now it was her standing up, moving past him, going to the closet. Josh followed her, standing in the doorway while she took off her jacket and unbuttoned her shirt. Since Josh said nothing, she spoke. “You're not the only one with trauma, Josh. I wish it were only you, and maybe the rest of the world could make it better, but all of us suffer in our own ways.”

“Even Devlin? You and him talk in bed when you're done fucking?”

Head cocking side to side as she pulled out her earrings, she said, “That's your big fear? That after we had sex we made fun of you? It's so specific.”

“That's what bullies do.”

“So you're just taunting me?” She turned, topless, only wearing pants and regarded him. His eyes darted over her bared skin, but his face remained grim. She said, “Amy was cruel. Amy taunted me. Made fun of me. Did it in ways I explained away, but then in later years I remembered it all differently. Realized some of those things she said were at my expense. That, yeah, behind my back, she might have made fun of me with the other girls. I was the unwitting butt of some of her jokes.”

“You're saying it like that's just life and I need to get over it.”

“Get over it or don't, Josh. You looked a lot better throwing a chair at Devlin than laying in bed and asking me to fantasize with you that I'm in love with his cock.”

Josh pinched the bridge of his nose like he was disgusted with her, done with her cruelty. “You don't think I'm a man.”

“No, I think you're a man,” she said. “I think I like it better when you stand up for yourself. I know I liked it when you came in the suite today and said

do it with him like you wanted me to. If you'd have been honest with yourself, maybe we could have all avoided what happened today."

"Then when the fuck would I have thrown a chair at Devlin? Don't try to manipulate me."

She rested an arm on the top of their closet dresser and leaned closer. "In your dream, the one in the tent, at Tiffany's...? Devlin put his cock in your hand..."

Josh grumbled, flinching from the insinuation. That he'd let it happen, that he hadn't ripped his giant dick off. That maybe his wife even thought her husband enjoyed holding his bully's cock. His eyes flashed, and he said, "There weren't any chairs to throw at him in the tent."

"And you were drunk," she said. "And Amy whispered instructions in your ear. Oh, and Devlin's always had it in for you, and that's been in your head since high school. You're just a Manchurian Candidate. None of this is because of you."

Josh flinched and looked away and for the very first time, she thought she might have got through to him.

She said, "Amy thinks it's funny to fuck with me. Devlin thinks it's funny to fuck with you. Amy probably did whisper something in your ear. But you're not hypnotized. You're not dosed with LSD or something. It turned you on. I don't hate that it turned you on, Josh. I hate that you pretend it didn't. I hate how you think I'm the only person responsible for it getting this far."

Josh stared at her; he tried to menace her, then his eyes would cloud with doubt. He looked away; he tried it all over again. His defenses had crumbled. His outer wall had been breached. The first dawning light shone through to his bailey, lighting her advancing army from behind.

She undid her waistband clasp and brushed past him. "If you'll excuse me, someone offered me a way out this afternoon, a way to bring us back together, and now I have to wash a disgusting man off my skin."

In the bathroom, she ran the faucet and waited. Josh didn't show. But she was committed to the shower now. She unzipped her pants.

Josh appeared in the doorway. She let her pants drop and stepped out of them. Naked now, no underwear. Josh watched her, expression morose, cheeks hollowed, brow low and heavy.

"I would do anything for you, Josh. I know you don't believe me. If you think about it, you'll see."

He breathed, watched, breathed. He said, "You betrayed me."

She bowed her head, apologetic. She'd already apologized. She stepped into the tub and left the sliding door open. The water was scalding hot; it burned her skin. Her face went under and she ran it over her hair, letting the tangles go heavy and drape on her shoulders. In the space of the opened door, she saw Josh's shirt drop beside the bath mat, followed by the movements of his shadow that told her he was getting undressed.

CHAPTER 10

HEAV'N OF HELL

The angle of Kimmy's jawline, the way it dipped, long eyelash lowered, sultry lips pouting, told him all he needed to know. She watched for him to join her. Wanted him to follow. Expected him to enter. While this seductive glance over a wet-glistening shoulder was an obvious act, there was still truth to her intention. Kimmy had lured him in here, and so what if she did? Kimmy wanted him. He always hoped to be wanted.

But wasn't it all artifice?

It couldn't be. If this was only an act, what would Kimmy gain? Only the same man she'd betrayed. If she'd strayed because he'd failed her or left her unfulfilled, why would she return to him? Perhaps Kimmy loved betrayal more than she loved him. Maybe she loved wickedness more than she loved him. Maybe he proved the perfect partner for a woman who adored cruelty.

He prayed that wasn't true.

Then there was a sharper blade slashed along his psyche's ripe flesh: perhaps Kimmy wanted them rejoined so she would be the one who performed the final severing.

It wasn't far-fetched. It wasn't impossible. And that crushed his heart.

He stepped into the shower as naked as she was and slid the door closed. Kimmy's head turned more, tracking him.

He said, "Don't worry. I didn't bring a chair."

"We love each other. I don't think you'd ever hurt me."

“What if I hurt you the way you hurt me?” Kimmy closed her eyes, nodded her chin down, acknowledging the harm she’d delivered, and he said, “You’re the one throwing chairs.”

The eye opened again, but she didn’t turn to face him and he hated how it made him think she knew how good she looked right now, that this might be her best angle, and how submissive she appeared; a naked and beautiful woman who could never harm a fly.

He held up a hand to block the fine mist scattering into his eyes, the shower water splashing off his wife’s tangled black hair that hung down her slender back. He dropped the hand to block out the view of her seductive mouth, to free himself from whatever hold she had on him. But that only brought attention lower, to her skinny waist, to her pert cheeks and her long legs, all glistening wet flesh. Between his legs his cock stood upright, eager for satisfaction. He’d suffered a long time today. Endured the gravest sexual macabre. He’d watched his most feared and most depraved fantasy come to life, and he hated it. But he wasn’t sure if it was hate at all. Kimmy was right in so many ways. What had ruined the show for him was Kimmy’s betrayal. Her lies. Witnessing the act, however, riled him in incomprehensible revolutions, twisting his most masculine core until it shed liquid lust. Hate and fury and desire and lust all at once. There were astounding moments.

His slippery front pressed her slippery back. His hands glided down her arms and circled her wrists. He brought her arms overhead and leaned into her until her cheek pressed the tiled wall under the shower-head. The spray cascaded down his back now and soaked his hair.

He said, “You don’t love me, you only love yourself.”

The belly of his throbbing cock found the seam between her cheeks and slipped between. The feeling was wild paradise. His cock swelled harder, flexing against the plush constraint of his wife’s lubricious ass.

“And you hate me,” she said.

“I only wish I did. I don’t even know how to feel anymore. No one’s ever hurt me like you just did.”

Kimmy grunted, and he was sure it wasn’t with a wounding or a sadness; he swore the sound came with an exasperation, like her husband was playing the same tired song again. But not a song, more like an article of faith. Anger rose once more, and he gritted his teeth. His hard cock-belly pressed into her slippery seam with greater force.

Kimmy said, “I’ll tell you a million times if you need it, Josh, but I never wanted to hurt you.”

He lifted her hands higher, pinned them harder to the bathroom tile. “You just didn’t care.”

That was something she didn’t argue. This statement she allowed to pass without a noted assessment. So he continued.

“You just wanted to get what you wanted, and you didn’t care about me at all.”

“I cared about you, Josh. Don’t make up things that aren’t true.”

“That’s your fucking job, right?” He dipped at the knees, his body wanting to brutalize her more than his mind did; wanting to degrade her, wanting to pull down her fancy attire and show her all she was worth underneath wasn’t much at all. His cock slipped along her crack like a card in a credit machine, drawing down until the point of his erection dropped between her legs. Then he rose, his cock head looking for a weakness in her armor, looking to sink inside her softness, to impale her with the sword she’d forged with her lies and manipulation. She’d honed his kink, tempered it on a forge burning with her white-hot wickedness.

Kimmy’s anus was tight, unyielding. But she didn’t struggle. She held still and allowed him to sink inside her, his cock wet with shower water.

“Ah, careful,” she warned him. He didn’t even want to be careful.

His cock squeaked and slipped, getting deeper inside her. “Did he ever fuck your ass?”

“Oh, Josh, don’t—you’re disgusting.”

“Disgusting because I want to know? He did, didn’t he? You’re so fucking rotten.”

Kimmy gasped again, the softest, sexiest sound he could imagine. A provocative mixture of impetus: his own dirty intrusion into her ass, combined with her recollection of when Devlin had done it to her. That’s what he believed. More anger rolled now. Devlin had fucked Kimmy’s ass. Kimmy had allowed it behind her husband’s back. Kimmy lied and lied and lied. And for what? So she could get an illicit fucking with a big tall man packed with muscle? A handsome asshole with a giant dick? . . . He squeezed her skinny wrists like he wanted to break them and pushed himself deeper inside her. “Are you thinking of it now? Are you thinking of him?”

“No,” Kimmy said, pinned to the wall and letting her husband take out the frustration she’d loaded on him in over-laden heavy haulage. Something she and her transport-biz lover had to work out together, determine the logistics of how poor Josh could manage such tonnage without breaking an axle.

“He fucked your ass?”

She nodded, her lips parted, eyes closed. He was sure she was thinking how much better Devlin Stone had fucked her ass. How much better Devlin could do it, with his big hands and his black eyes and his horse cock. Hate and pure bile-inducing disgust swelled his cock even harder. Brought a muscular surge beginning somewhere near his asshole. He thrust deep into her. Drew back and did it again, this time holding it, impaling her with every inch, lifting her onto her toes. Her hands went to fists and her wrists twisted in his grip. He held them firm.

“God, I fucking hate you so much,” he growled.

She whimpered, but stayed resilient, answering, “No, you don’t.”

And he didn't. He should. And holy shit did he want to. He wanted to take all of her stupid expensive clothes, throw them out the window, take her shit, any single fucking thing that reminded him of her, and break it over his knee. He wanted to shout and scream and he wanted to hurt her as much as she had hurt him. But he couldn't do that. He'd never harm her. And she didn't love him from the same angle he loved her. So how the hell could he give the same hurt back to her? Fuck her bully? Fuck Amy behind her back? That sounded like more harm to him than to Kimmy. He had nothing. Nothing but suffering. It would be so easy to let go, let his grip on this cliff-side precipice release, find freedom splattered on the ground below...

He let his tight grip loosen but still held her wrists, his thumb caressing her skin, wanting to kiss her neck, to nuzzle his mouth and nose under her ear, feel her wet hair on his cheek. He wanted to make love to her. To win her back. Like a chump. Like a goddamn fucking chump. She was a bitch who spread her legs for his sworn enemy. Lied to his face. Made him believe they were in this together, made him believe it was all for him. Acted like the novice, an uninitiated saint trying to comprehend her husband's ill-shaped kink as he struggled to explain whatever it was he wanted. Putting it in his head so she could get fucked better. Luring, leading, coaxing, nourishing and nurturing the sin that beat in her heart, getting her dumb husband to ask her to do the very thing she was already doing behind his back. A fucking cunt. An evil, despicable whore.

He withdrew and then pushed himself in deeper, making Kimmy wince and whimper, then closing his eyes tight, growling, hating himself more than he hated her right now. Or at least should. Wishing none of this had happened, that they could be transported back in time. That this was all a dream, that he was still inside the tent outside of Tiffany's cottage, and he was still drunk, and soon he'd wake, taught the lessons of some ghost of summer future.

He let her wrists go, rested his forehead on the crown of her skull, lovely warm water running his back. "I hate you so much, Kimmy. I hate you so fucking much," he said, now grabbing her little breasts and squeezing them. Her nipples were swollen against his palm.

Her slick hands went over the backs of his and she angled her ass so he could fuck it. The act was lurid and he couldn't stop the cannon-blast thought that she'd shared herself like this with Devlin. Done it behind his back.

His mouth supped the water draining from her black hair. His teeth raked her back; he bit at her collar and her neck. "Did he do it?" he bit and grunted, eyes squeezed shut again. "Did he fuck your ass?"

She gasped, "Yeah," and he hated the instant click of hydraulic turnout switches in his ears, two enormous railway tracks heading different directions lining up again, ready to send their loaded freight train to the registered destination.

His hips propelled against her rump in an exquisite dance of rolling and dropping and swiveling, his wife's cheeks patting against his drive, her ass gripping his cock tight.

He asked her where, and Kimmy hesitated, but she panted with his thrusts, her head rolling on her long neck, her nails scratching his hands. "Cayman," she admitted at last, uttering the lone word in a single breathy syllable.

"He fucked your ass in his hotel room while I waited?" His voice was tinged with rage and yet there was something electrical humming along the surface of his brain, a storm surging over thirsty sunbaked farmland.

"The lawyer's," she gasped now, and his mind reeled. There was so much he didn't know that was his to hear. He demanded it. She was his wife, and this information was his. He deserved the truth. But the revelations aroused him through the celestial light bathing his wife's wickedness. The impossible duality of Kimmy's claim: she betrayed him because she loved him.

It was too much to assimilate, the particles too large for the finer mesh today's escapade had inserted into his basket. His thrusts stopped, his interstate clogged with traffic, ears ringing, shower water splashing off his forehead. Kimmy wouldn't let him retreat, keeping his cock imbedded in her ass by holding onto his wrists now, keeping him locked in place like

they were rutting dogs. Her hips shunted back and forth, her ass sucking on his cock. He leaned over her back, resting his forehead between her shoulder blades.

Her rearward thrusting slowed to a more seductive rhythm, and she interlinked their fingers, holding his hands over her chest. She quarter-turned, making sure he would hear her, saying now, “I showed you his true form. Aren’t you going to thank me?”

He scoffed and lifted off her back, his hips taking up her rhythm and meeting her thrusts. He pushed her forward and pinned her front to the tiled wall. “Thank you for that? I watched him fucking shoot his disgusting load all over himself. You’re the fucking devil.”

“I showed you Devlin Stone on his hands and knees, crawling on the floor like a dog. I put that chair in your hands.”

And he pictured it: Devlin in a robe, down on his hands and knees. Man, his heart had hammered in the moment. Lightning had shot through every synapse in his body. He’d never been more sure of his own righteousness in any moment he could remember. He said, “I’m the one who threw it.”

“You threw it, Josh. And then you saw him. That’s who he is. He’s a fucking nobody. It’s you and me. We’re the real people. He’s a nothing. I freed you. I gave you manhood.”

CHAPTER 11

DIVINE DISPLEASURE

He said, “You’re proud you turned me to violence?”

Kimmy licked her lower lip, and he watched her shining pink tongue retract, the motion such a sultry thing he imagined what he’d done turned her on in some way. She said, “A display of displeasure, Josh. An instruction from one man to another. One you could never show before because of the retribution, your fear of what he would do for revenge.”

Those words chilled him, and his arms and fingers prickled with a swift-encroaching dread. What he’d done wouldn’t pass unnoticed. He’d hit Devlin with a chair. Hit him in the head; marred his face. High school rules dictated an imposed punishment. Devlin couldn’t let that action go without reprisal. There was no way. Josh had humiliated Devlin in front of his girlfriend. His mind raced like it would in high school; hyper vigilance commanded his nervous system now and his breaths quickened, thinking of when it might happen, picturing Devlin and Rumble and some other familiar antagonists waiting for him outside his apartment right now, rubbing wet dog shit on his door handles as a mere appetizer for their savage feast. Angry young males ten times more a man than he was, eager to strip his weak flesh from brittle bone.

And with his cock plugged into his beautiful wife’s ass, it was like she’d read his mind, quarter-turning to the opposite side now, seeking his eyes for a connection and saying, “You were the man today, Josh. He was the boy. Don’t you see it? Devlin plays immature games, boys’ games. We’re adults, we’re playing adult games.”

“I don’t want to play any games anymore.”

She said, “You were the man today. You told me what you wanted. You knew what it was. You wanted me to save myself. You wanted us to be together.”

His head whipped to the side, trying to avoid her silky words, trying to avoid the polished truth she tried to poison him with.

“When it didn’t go how you wanted, you let Devlin know.”

He growled and fucked into her ass hard. She squeaked a sound of minimal discomfort. He said, “You humiliated me.”

And Kimmy said, “Don’t you want that? If you don’t, just tell me you don’t.”

“Of course I don’t want that. Why would I want that?”

“I don’t know how it works, Josh. But when you tell me what you want, I’ll make it happen. I’ll do anything for you.”

He bared his teeth and hid his face in her wet mane, psyche twisting with shame. He’d asked her to fuck Devlin today and if she did, he’d let her go from punishment, absolve her sins.

Had he ruined it? Just like she claimed Devlin had ruined it? Devlin had lured him away from his union with Kimmy, whispered provocative things in his ear and encouraged him away from the one who would keep him safe. He’d joined sides with the enemy, and allowed their enemy to turn his campaign against Kimmy like a weapon. Maybe, at one time, he would have to admit he really did want this to happen. But instead of working with Kimmy, he let Devlin show Kimmy’s lies to him in the most terrible light, and he ended up in a hotel room asking for the very thing she would have delivered him anyway—on her own time and in her own terms and for his benefit. He’d been Devlin’s unwitting pawn today.

Devlin had used him against Kimmy. Taken away his wife’s control of a game in which she sought not only his preservation, but his satisfaction as well.

But it wasn't so simple, it wasn't so clear to see, more like a murky shape in a fog, or lying in the grass and looking at clouds, making up images you could see inside them.

He said, "Why would you lead me along? Why wouldn't you just tell me what you were doing? Why wouldn't you be honest with me?"

"You know why."

"Because you're a liar."

"Yes, because I'm a liar. I wanted to get away with it. I wanted to get away with what I'd done, and still make you happy."

The answer irritated him. Bothered him. Frustrated him. He withdrew his cock from her and retreated, disgusted with her lies and her betrayal all over again. "You're still lying," he said, grabbing his face, rubbing his brow, hiding his eyes from the sight of her naked body. His cock still throbbed and ached to be returned to her tight scabbard. "Lying and dignifying the awful thing you did. You fucking cheated on me with Devlin Stone. You fucked him at Tiffany's." His hands snapped to his sides in fists. He was a half second from thumping the inset soap dish, wanting destruction, wanting his wife to know this wasn't something she could smooth. The warps and bumps her actions had pushed into the smooth plain of their marriage could never be hidden. They would always stand out. "And for what? For a fuck with Devlin? You don't even like him."

"I don't know why, Josh. I don't know. But I hate what I did, I—"

"You've got to be fucking kidding me," he said, reeling in disbelief, an insane tidal wave of hilarity rising up, his wife clinging to the flimsiest life preserver and committed to convincing the storming, endless sea nothing would drown her.

Her chin dipped, and she went silent, standing naked, nipples hard, water cascading around her head like a halo, rivulets streaming the curves and angles of her lean body. She lifted a hand to cup the spray and deflect it, run it down her breasts; not to entice him, but to keep the spray from his eyes.

She said, “It was a mistake. I made a huge mistake and I’m telling you I don’t know why. I don’t know why I did it.”

“I failed you. You don’t love me. What is it?”

“You never failed me, Josh. And I love you. I love you more now than ever.”

Sharp retorts sizzled on his tongue, but he kept his mouth shut. She looked up now and there was something new in her black eyes he couldn’t recognize. And if it was something he thought he didn’t recognize, there was a chance it was honesty.

She dropped the hand and retrieved the soap from the dish he’d wanted to smash. She rubbed it between her leg hands, eyes now aside, her expression pensive. She lathered, then ran hands on her chest and arms and underarms. He watched the suds collect on her aroused nipples. She said, “I was a wreck. You know that.”

He didn’t have to speculate or ask for clarification. This spring had seen the end of all their fresh hopes of starting a family. He let her talk, still watching her hands soap herself, getting between her thighs now.

“We were so close. We had it. You know what I mean. We were right there. And then the next thing I knew, we had nothing. I didn’t want to go back to work. I made baskets in the house so I wouldn’t have to step outside. I didn’t want anyone to look at me, see me, talk to me. But I kept fighting. I made baskets because doing nothing would kill me.” Her hands stilled on either side of her taut navel, her eyes staring like they were seeing something bigger than anything in the shower with them. “Fighting with Devlin made me feel something. I betrayed you and maybe I told myself that was okay.”

“Okay how?”

Her eyes widened and right away he knew whatever it was she had in her mind, it was gargantuan and he wouldn’t want to hear it. It might be worse than her cheating with Devlin. She exhaled through her mouth, her lips

stuck and puffing out. Then she sucked her lower lip, held it clamped under her teeth, stopping herself from speaking.

He said, “I failed you. I’m not a man. Just like Devlin said.”

Her expression was an honest portrayal of correction; he’d got it wrong, and she didn’t want him thinking that. He said, “What then? What is it?”

“I failed you.”

“Hey,” he said, taking her shoulders. “No, you didn’t. I don’t think that at all.”

“I know you don’t. But I did fail you. So, like, if I cheated it would be because I was mad at you, punishing you. Because you failed me.”

His hands slipped down her slippery arms and fell to his side. She touched his arms.

She acknowledged what he must be thinking. “It doesn’t make sense.”

“I don’t understand, Kimmy.”

“I know. I wanted to be mad at someone else so I could stop being mad at myself. I was the ultimate failure. All I wanted was to have your baby and live a life in a house, and...”

He sighed, and looked around, his rage deflated in the face of a tender and uncomfortable admission.

She said, “And then we’re at tiffany’s and this guy I dislike, who Amy taunted me with and leveraged against me, he’s arguing with me and my heart is pounding. Not with like affection or any kind of attraction, but it’s pumping. I hate this guy. I hate what he represents, I hate who he is. Fuck, Josh, I hate what he has. He doesn’t deserve it. He’s cocky, he’s arrogant, he looks down on people who are so much better than him. And he can get away with it. His dad owns a shipping company. He works there, he’s an executive, and he has no brain. And then he’s saying the most arrogant shit, and we start . . . I told you what happened.”

Cruelty crystallized in his mind's eye; he could reject her paltry exegesis, belittle her assuaging the ultimate weaponized betrayal. But he watched her, his new savvy assessing her body language and eyes for the lie. No more untruths would spin from those sultry lips that could convince him.

She was still lost in her confession and the way she spoke made him think she was realizing some of these things for the very first time. She said, "That Mercedes he shows up in. We're in our sensible vehicle, showing the planet kindness. . . . We deserve the gifts. Not him."

Her brow lowered, and her lips slimmed in a mask of real envy.

Then she shook her head, wriggled free from the clutches of her dark reverie, and looked at him. It was like she'd come out of hypnosis. Her eyes had changed.

She grabbed the bar of soap again and worked a new lather between her palms.

He said, "I don't forgive you."

Her hands stilled. "I don't want forgiveness. You asked me why, and that's the closest thing to it."

"You weren't going to run off with him, leave in that Mercedes you love? Weren't going to move into his luxury apartment?"

Her hands resumed the lathering, then she returned the soap to the dish. She cupped his balls and gripped his shaft. He was still hard as steel, and the slipperiness on the end of his cock had his knees dipping and his vision whitening for a brief flash. But she wasn't ignoring him or changing the subject. She said, "I want to wreck him, Josh. I want to ruin his life."

CHAPTER 12

THE CENTER OF A SOLEMN CLOUD

Josh followed her from the bathroom into the bedroom. That seductive talk of revenge had muted him. His expression was dumbfounded, his eyes empty; trust lurked, and Josh wanted to trust what she said was true.

At the foot of the bed, she paused, using the clean white towel she wore over her shoulders to scrub water from her hair. Then she tossed away the towel, turned and sat naked on their bed. Josh kept his distance, a half dozen feet away, one hand holding closed the towel around his waist. Water dropped from a curled lock over his forehead in a steady rhythm. Those lost eyes of his were timid on her; his brow troubled. He would want what she said to be the truth, but he couldn't help but be afraid. He still feared Devlin Stone. Anxious mechanisms were beating contrary thoughts back and forth behind those eyes like Olympic ping-pong. Yes! Destroy him! But how? What if you fail? What if you destroy him? What would Devlin do in return? Maybe we should just keep our heads down. Then again...

She encouraged Josh closer. The closer he got, the more she raised her chin, and soon he stood tall above her and she showed him a wan smile. There was so much she needed to tell him. Much he needed to know. But the first thing she should take care of humped out the front of his towel.

Her arms circled his waist, and she embraced his hips, hugging her cheek against the hardness underneath the towel. Fingers tucking under the soft terry material, she sat back again, running the fingers around to break loose the towel, freeing the fold-over hitch beneath Josh's hand. The towel came free and fell to the bedroom floor. She pressed her lips to Josh's pubic pad, kissing his flesh, his cock hard and upright at her cheek. Her hands smoothed over his skin; his hips, his waist. Soon, Josh's hands moved, cupping the sides of her head overtop her damp and shower-stringy hair.

Josh succumbed. Neither of them were innocent, each of them guilty of their own crimes. But she was a betrayer, and Josh would never betray her. What she had done to their marriage couldn't be explained. She'd tried to frame the madness that had consumed her since the spring; some of the details pre-considered, some of it spun on the fly.

The kisses increased in suction and wetness and made their inexorable journey to the central structure of Josh's psyche. His instrument of perpetual masculinity; the physical representation of his manhood that someone had conditioned him to believe was inadequate. And she'd reinforced that belief, sleeping with the man who'd prompted it in the first place, pursuing the man, fetishizing his huge penis. Finding out that while her husband was adequate her own unique biology responded to monstrous phallic intrusion. Wickedness and libertine primal lust painted wonderful colors in her mind. The fat end of Devlin's long cock touched a wild place inside her that prickled heat and passion and the wettest pleasure. . . . But Josh was her partner. Josh was her husband. He was the boy she'd fallen in love with. The man she betrayed. There was no betrayal without a union; they were united. Had been at the start. In love and ready for a family. The betrayal had value. The betrayal shone a light on what she'd had. She'd been more than careless with Josh's love. She had been destructive. Sometimes, in the aftermath of chaos, a new life would grow.

Josh's sack tightened when her kisses found it. His body weight shifted; his hips inched forward. When she looked up she saw something lively in his eyes; desire had assumed control at last.

No more could she assume the lead role in Josh's travels through depravity. No sense in it anymore; no need. There was no more to conceal. At least not as far as her activities with Devlin were concerned. Devlin whispered their secrets in her husband's ear behind her back. And for what? To gain control of her? No. Not likely. To be the boss. A role he couldn't fulfill. A role he only imagined suited him. Devlin existed in a comfortable fold of immaturity, protected by privilege and his daddy's money. Devlin betrayed her for fun. Devlin betrayed her because he'd convinced himself he knew all the angles, a master of 4D chess. She kissed the belly of Josh's cock, her lips pushing it back to his stomach. Devlin would pay for hurting Josh.

Her tongue swathed upward until the point of Josh's erection speared her mouth. She sucked him, putting her hands on his hips and bobbing her head. Doing it slow and seductive, letting him know this was only the foreplay. Her hands kneaded his balls, his sack shrunken, his cock twitching with delight in her mouth. His hands gripped her head and his hips urged his cock in and out of her sucking mouth. Then she was pushing back, looking up at him, eyes brimming with apology, wanting him to climb on top of her and get his satisfaction. Get everything he deserved; whatever it was he needed. Their union was the only thing that mattered. There was nothing if they weren't together.

Being bad to Josh aroused her. His weaknesses lured her closer to him, wanting him to display his fears. There was dominant action and reward for terrorizing someone you loved; playing pranks, hiding behind doors, or jumping out of closets, sharing the fun. And yet, displaying your power over another at the same time.

With her eyes on his, she elbow-walked rearward, shimmying her hips, working herself up to the pillows. To lay in their marital bed together. To do marital things together. Josh's eyes drifted from hers to watch her body writhe. The lust rose in him. His cock bobbed with his heartbeat, arrow-straight, glistening with her saliva. He loved her body. Had always loved it. Even when she hadn't used it to control him. Even when she was a timid mouse working in immigration, wanting to do the right thing, wanting to help others.

Josh followed on his knees, trudging in her trail, mesmerized. At the pillows, she lay her head back, wanting him to take her. She parted her legs. Josh looked between them. She could read misery in the lust now. Josh remembering what Devlin had done to her today. She covered her pussy with her hands, breaking the spell. They'd showered. They'd cleaned. The hotel in Yorkville was an hour away. They were home in their bed. What she'd done with Devlin Stone faded with each minute into a dream.

Josh's eyes met hers again, and she stayed steady until he was with her, knees between her legs, lowering over top of her. Her hands went to his neck and pulled his kiss close, her mouth sealing on his, her tongue parting

his lips. Then she was caressing him; his back, his sides, and doing it with love.

Josh pierced her. His iron rod sliding into her seam. She grunted and exhaled, closing her legs on him. Devlin had fucked her, and his cock was huge. Josh had fucked her ass. She was sensitive, but receptive. But her unconscious response to his entry reminded Josh she'd been used. It would be all he could think of. She didn't want that, but she wouldn't stop it. Wouldn't veer him away from those thoughts. She didn't have to anymore. She didn't have to hide from him that she was fucking Devlin Stone. She didn't have to pretend Josh's kink aroused her. She didn't have to twist the erotic knife in her husband with dirty spoken fantasies, get him up on his toes and surrendering to her will, closing his eyes to the truth. There was no more make-believe. Josh's fantasies were real and he could do with them whatever he wanted. He could deny they were his, pretend Amy whispered a magic curse in his ears, but she would never buy that. And deep down Josh had to face it as well. No one could conjure behavior you abhorred. Josh liked it. She liked that Josh liked it. She liked doing the things that made him squirm.

The room was quiet. No words spoken. Just late-day married sex in their bedroom, the wet squish-squish of Josh's penis inside her, gentle breaths coming quicker, the silky sounds of their joined flesh, the rustle of the bedding. Josh looked down between them while he fucked her and she rubbed his back and drew nail-diagrams on his skin. He'd seen her take mighty girth today. His narrower dick went in and out with ease. These would be his thoughts. He'd seen his high school bully's massive cock push out her tummy in a fat node between her hips. Josh's arousal was her arousal.

She began to pant, playing in her mind what she would look like this afternoon gored by Devlin's beefy dick. Josh had watched her getting pounded and degraded and coming like crazy on Devlin's manhood. With her eyes closed tight, she played out the scene from Josh's viewpoint, seeing her own long legs wrapped around Devlin's hips, his powerful thighs flexing, those thick arms holding her in place. And then Devlin's long dick

rubbing on her deepest pleasure spot, making her sing, making her come. Making her squirt all over Devlin's muscular front.

Josh squirmed, his hips rolling against hers, inoffensive, careful. He spoke his fear: "Are you thinking of him?"

"Yes," she said, then, more accurate. "No, thinking of you watching me."

He groaned, held his cock deep inside her. "Did you like it?"

"I loved it, Josh. I really loved it."

Then Josh was gasping and trembling, stilling himself, his cock speared inside her and flexing, filling her up with his own seed. She kissed his ear and bit his earlobe while he came, drawing out the pleasure, wanting to whisper vile things into his thoughts, but too wary of making a mistake, stepping on a landmine. She bit her lips and stared at the ceiling, her mind alive with all the terrible things she could say to him right now, things that would drive him wilder than he'd ever imagined.

Josh's orgasm went on for a long time, his cock twitching, his wetness flooding, his breaths coming in shaky snorts. At last, he grunted and heaved, collapsing on her, ashamed of his performance. Wishing he was Devlin. Wishing he could do the things to her Devlin Stone did. He tried to withdraw, but she cinched her thighs on him, closed her arms around his neck. "Stay inside me," she whispered. "I want to feel you go soft. I just want to feel you with me."

Josh rolled his head on her collar, his breath hot and wet against her neck, panting, trying to recover from his orgasm. She held him as his erection faded and his semen went cold and slipped down between her cheeks. It was a long and tender moment, and she loved the strength it delivered her heart.

When the moment passed at last she loosened her hold and played with his hair. His soft penis slipped out of her. She whispered, "We're free now." Devlin Stone could hold them no more. He couldn't play them against each

other. Devlin only ever saw the steps right in front of him and wanted everyone to marvel at that mediocre feat.

She held Josh's head and put her forehead against his, hoping he could feel some kind of restoration in his heart, hoping he would feel their union, want from her all she could deliver.

She kissed the tip of his nose, still holding his cheeks, Josh lifting, their gazes meeting. She smiled, saying, hushed and reverent, "Josh, I'm pregnant again."

CHAPTER 13

HAPPY WALKS AND SHADES

The room spun. The cruelty astounded him. He recoiled, aghast, devastated. Kimmy had lured him close so she could sink a fatal blade into his heart. He backed away from her, bewildered, stunned, the whole world pulled out from under him, snatched by an unseen magician's hand. Kimmy pursued him, her face twisted in mock confusion. When she saw he was speechless, she said, "What is it? Why are you...?"

He covered his hands over his face. "Kimmy, you..."

Kimmy's hands went around his wrists. "Josh, wait, it's not . . . It's not..."

His hands came away, and he studied her face, looking in her eyes to see behind this bewildered facade, knowing malevolence burned behind them. He could barely speak, his throat constricted. He finished her denial: "It's not his?"

Her hands fell from his wrists and she now she spoke in a hushed tone. "It's not."

"Kimmy, oh my god," he said, retreating further, sliding off the bed, grabbing his towel, hating his nakedness, hating the weakness that had followed his wife's lure, putting his dick inside her because it shut his brain off when he did.

She called after him, but he was headed to the closet, needing to be clad in the armor of underwear and jeans and flannel. He'd never felt more vulnerable in his life. She pleaded, and he turned, saw her on the bed, covering her own nudity, legs together, on her knees, arm over her breasts. She said, "I'm on the pill."

He grunted and reeled, fleeing into the closet and putting on underwear, his dick flinging the stringy wet conjured by his wife's extreme indecency. Hypnotizing him into fucking her when he should know better. Underwear, then jeans, throwing a T-shirt on . . . Kimmy was in the doorway now, wrapped in the robe she kept in the bathroom. She said it again, told him she was on the pill as if he hadn't heard her the first time.

"Get out of the closet, please," he said, pulling a sweatshirt over his head, feeling trapped with her blocking the door.

"Josh, you're acting crazy. I don't think you know—"

He had the sweatshirt on now, tugging it to his waist, head popping out of the hood. "You weren't on the pill at fucking Tiffany's, were you?" That shut her up. He said, "I know you weren't."

"Josh, I wouldn't be happy about being pregnant if I thought it wasn't yours."

"Yeah, you would," he said. "You'd do it to trick me. You'd do it to get away with it."

Kimmy's brow lowered in anger, and now she wasn't so sweet or pleading, saying, "Be careful what you're saying, Josh."

"Or what? You'll have an affair with my high school bully? Get pregnant?"

Kimmy saw she couldn't argue the point, and seeing acceptance in her posture uplifted him, amplified his righteousness. As she leaned on the doorframe and put a hand to her temple, he moved closer, saying, "At the very best, Kimmy, why the fuck would you tell me you're pregnant on the day I watched Devlin Stone fuck you? Why would you forever link those two things?"

Her hand dropped to her side, and she sighed, speaking with her eyes closed, saying, "Josh, we're going to have a baby. We're going to have our family."

He said, “Maybe I didn’t plant it deep enough. Maybe if you give birth it’s because it’s Devlin’s.” He tried to step past her, but she clung to him.

“Don’t be crazy, Josh. You’re taking this the wrong way. Don’t leave, don’t take off on me.”

“Why not?” He said, “I’m a coward, remember? It’s the thing I’m good at,” and pushed her off of him, storming out of the closet and into their bedroom.

Kimmy followed, pleading again, “Please, Josh, please don’t leave me. Stay and talk, hear me out.”

He’d hated referring to himself as a coward, had only said it to hurt her, make her feel bad for ever calling him one. He paused, hand on the bedroom door, dropping his chin down, knowing every ion in his body wanted to escape Kimmy’s electromagnetic force. The closer she came, the greater the force, and the greater pain loaded onto his heart. In that paused moment of time he could picture Devlin’s baby growing inside the woman he loved, and the woman he loved liking that it was Devlin’s baby, and the two of them laughing behind his back. He recoiled when she touched him.

She said, “I know, okay? I know how it sounds. I didn’t think how it would sound before I . . . I’m selfish. Okay? I know I’m selfish. I felt so great a minute ago, so glad we were in bed together, I wanted to tell you something good, something that would make you happy.”

“You’re insane,” he said. “You’re crazy.”

“Josh, I love you.” Her smooth brow knit into a furrow. “How can you say that? I love you.”

He still looked down at his hand on the door lever. “If it’s Devlin’s will you get rid of it?”

She said, “It’s not Devlin’s. Don’t be ridiculous.”

He scoffed at her brazenness, looking at her now. “Will you get rid of it?”

“It? It’s our baby, Josh.”

“And if it’s Devlin’s...?”

“It’s not,” she said, jaw clenching.

“You’re kidding me. One hundred percent sure. You expect me to what? Raise my bully’s baby with you?”

“Josh, stop saying that,” she said, slouching, putting up her hands on either side of her head like she wanted to cover her ears. “Please, please . . . I’m talking about our baby.”

He said, “You’re talking about a baby,” cold, detached.

The hands near her ears went to her mouth, and he could see her eyes swell with tears. It didn’t make him feel good, but he would never fall for her trickery again. His own eyes began to tear in sympathy, knowing she wasn’t faking the misery he saw now. They’d suffered in the spring, each of them in their own way. A pregnancy would mean something incredible to her, but she’d betrayed him and lost his trust. “You can lie some more, tell me there’s no way it’s Devlin’s, but I won’t believe you. I just won’t.”

“I’m not trying to,” she said, voice a thin whisper, tears rolling on her cheeks now.

“I know you’re going to go to work tomorrow with Devlin. I know you’re pregnant now. What do you want me to do, stand by your side and let you make a fool out of me?”

“Josh, don’t say that. You’re not a fool—”

“Not anymore,” he said and levered the door. Kimmy stopped him with a hand on his arm. He regarded her. Her eyes had taken on an expression of horror.

She said, “I don’t want to be superstitious...”

“But what?”

“Don’t” she said, shaking her head, lips slimming.

“Don’t what? Leave you? You want me to stay and let you destroy me?”

“The negativity,” she said. “It’s bad. It’s a bad start.”

He scoffed again. “A bad start? What if I’m not even a part of it?”

“You are,” she pleaded, nails digging through his sweatshirt into his bicep.
“You’re all of it.”

“Look in my eyes and tell me something,” he said.

Kimmy’s sniveling eyes met his, knowing he would say something that would hurt her. More tears; her cheeks had reddened. He asked it anyway.
“Tell me there’s not a single chance it’s Devlin’s. Lie to my face one more time.”

Her hand dropped, and she said, “It’s yours.”

Cruelty came to him easier now, and he said, “Do you even want it to be?”
Kimmy’s look of unambiguous anguish was exquisite, and he enjoyed it for only a fraction of a second before he felt shame and guilt. Still, he yanked open the door and left. The further he marched down the hall, the more he hoped she would pursue him. He stopped at the kitchen, turned back, disheartened to see she hadn’t.

He held fists to his cheeks, pressing knuckles into the hollows, staring with madness into the kitchen, feeling his insides tearing apart. Remorse loomed the strongest; remorse for the direction he’d allowed their relationship to take. Despair over where his relationship should be. His toes curled the edge of demise’s precipice. A premonition swelled inside him that if he departed there would be nothing when he returned. Kimmy had just told him she was pregnant. Had just told him they would have a baby...

But even that simple recollection turned his stomach. Not his. Not his. He stomped past the kitchen to the apartment door, but stopped again, face twisting up in the cold paralysis of indecision. Wanting to harm Kimmy but

wanting to console her. Console her for the harshness of his words, wanting to console her because she might be pregnant with his child. And they'd suffered before.

When he turned to the kitchen, Kimmy was there. Beautiful in her bathrobe and her clinging hair, sadness in her eyes. Kimmy could lie and betray, but she was no thespian. She could only portray the cold. The tears, the grief, the misery were all real.

She said, "I cared. You don't know how much I cared. You don't know how much hurt I saved you from. I wanted this for you, but I wanted it in your own time. Devlin's too stupid to care. Devlin ruined it."

"You can't stop talking about him," he said, words of anger, but spoken in quiet monotone, both of them stating harsh things and wanting them to be heard enough to squelch the emotion that would have them tearing each other to shreds. "You're obsessed with him."

"You are too, Josh," she whispered.

"No. I'm not. It's you." He met her eyes. "You force me to think about him every day. Every day, Kimmy." Her lips pinched closed, and she looked down. He said, "Every day since Tiffany's party Devlin Stone is in my head. Because of what you did. Don't you see it? You brought this on me. On us."

He watched as her face contorted, biting her own lips, shaking her head. She said, "Devlin's a fool. He thinks he can start his own thing, thinks he has what it takes. He doesn't see what he has. Doesn't see how it works. He wants to make his mark, impress his daddy, but he has no idea what he's doing."

"You are obsessed with him, Kimmy. He's all you can talk about."

She spoke through gritted teeth. "I talk about him because he's in my way."

"You think I want revenge? I don't. I want this to be over—fuck, I want it to never have happened, but..."

Kimmy crossed her arms, eyes soft and expression open.

He dipped his chin and exhaled. “You’re going to go to work tomorrow. You’re going to have your baby. Even if it’s Devlin’s.”

She showed him an expression of restrained denial, hating that she had to allow him to state something she didn’t believe. But her actions had made this moment; her betrayal had carved it from a solid block of marble. There was nothing she could say.

He looked up at the ceiling. “You know, everything you’ve done to me, I can’t believe I’m not screaming and ranting and raving like a lunatic. I wanted to throw everything you own out the window. Now look at me. Leaving again with my tail between my legs. I’m your coward, remember?”

She rolled her eyes up and shook her head, more tears coming.

“I’m no coward, Kimmy. I’d fight for you to the end. I’d fight to the death for you. Problem is you’re the villain. You’re the enemy. You’re the one who wants to destroy me.”

“I don’t want you to go,” she said, voice quivering. “I want you to stay.”

He nodded, but looked away. “I think that would be the worst thing I could do.”

She covered her mouth and squeezed tears from her eyes.

He grabbed his car keys and left without saying goodbye.

CHAPTER 14

GURGLING IN BLACK MUD

Kimmy came out of their apartment dressed for work, seven o'clock in the morning. Josh sat in the Qashqai and watched, hoping she wouldn't see him parked on the street running along the front of their apartment building. It would be a terrible start to the already awful morning. But Kimmy didn't see him, strutting stone-faced to her Leaf and unlocking it with the fob. He waited for her to get it started and pull out of the lot, head the opposite way from him, off to hit the 401 and get into work. Get to work for Devlin Stone.

He watched her dot on his Find My Phone, seeing her loop the clover leaf and get on the highway before he pulled into the parking lot and went up to their apartment. Last night he'd gone and booked a room at the Best Western on his credit card.

What was Kimmy thinking, walking to her car this early morning? Her face had been unreadable. What had he expected? Had he expected her to stumble her way to the car, perhaps fall against it for a moment before gathering herself? Maybe he'd expected her not to go at all.

And that was it. The most satisfactory answer. That's what he wanted. He wanted his wife to sacrifice this job she loved for the sake of their marriage.

Wasn't their marriage worth it?

But no, he watched his wife get up the next morning after the tragic end to their marriage (I mean, wasn't it?) get dressed and made up and get in her car and drive to work for the man who'd slayed them. Who'd taken his mighty ten-inch battle-axe and cleaved their union in two.

Pregnant.

Pregnant, he thought, getting under the shower stream. Just yesterday he'd fucked Kimmy in here. Put his dick in her ass even though she'd shown him the worst things that had gone on behind his back this summer.

Done it because you asked her to.

Yeah, but so what?

What did you think it would look like?

None of it mattered. Kimmy was pregnant. Kimmy was pregnant, and, yeah, it would most likely be his baby.

This was what he'd thought, up all night staring at the ceiling of the Best Western's hundred-thirty dollar a night room. Kimmy was pregnant with his child. They should be celebrating.

But what?

Kimmy had let a demon into their marriage. She'd betrayed them. She'd ruined them with her lust and her betrayal. Yes, somehow, he'd sexualized the betrayal, but that wasn't his own doing. Forces had worked together to make that happen. Had worked behind the scenes to mold his thinking into that awful shape. That was the somehow. It wasn't a mystery.

And yet, alone in that bed last night in the sterile hotel room, all he could think was that he might be a father. As much as he'd like to offload the responsibility to others, the thinking was his. Maybe they'd pointed him in the direction, but he'd taken the steps. He'd even encouraged it.

He might be a father.

If the baby wasn't his, Kimmy and her devil offspring could go fuck off into the mountains and never come back. But what if he was a father?

The how of their marital repair eluded him. It would elude anyone. How would one come back to a marriage after such devastation?

With his hands spread on the tiled wall below the shower head, he let the spray cascade over his back and neck. Eyes shut tight, he could picture a perfect baby. A beautiful creation wailing at the surprise dawning of a mortal existence, looking for love, looking for care. A product of his own loins and a product of the woman he loved. And who swore still loved him. Birthed from her canal.

A deep canal where a man whom he hated had stuck his oversized hose and irrigated Kimmy's fields with his healthy fertilizer.

The hands on the wall turned to fists, and he beat a wet and angry rhythm.

What should be the grandest elation he'd allowed to pervert into the starkest betrayal.

It was Devlin. It was Amy. . . . It was Kimmy.

But it was him, too.

In the closet now, he began to dress for work. Kimmy had taken the suit she'd bought him and hung it back up again. Did she care for him, or care for the degeneracy the suit stood for?

He'd spent last night at a motel because he didn't want to go to Meyer's in the state he was in. What had happened between him and Kimmy was too big to even understand. If he couldn't understand it, how could he sit with Meyer and try to talk it out without revealing the grandest shame a man could endure? And he'd walked into it willingly. Had set himself up for such a devastation.

Later, combing his hair in the mirror, he realized despite his wifely condemnation, he was going to work, too. He'd condemned Kimmy, but here he was, sneaking into his own apartment so he could get showered and ready for work.

His reflection showed a stark image; a man with dark eyes and hollowed cheeks; a shell, ready to crack.

But there were things he knew; things that gleamed in the rubble of their marital rubble. Kimmy would have to earn her way back. He couldn't crawl to her. She would never respect him again—and she shouldn't.

Kimmy would have to prove her devotion.

But what if she was pregnant with your own perfect little baby?

Nothing mattered but Kimmy's return.

But with an unfortunate meeting of his own gaze in the mirror, he envisioned Kimmy and Devlin together and the baby was theirs, and Kimmy looked in Devlin's black eyes, and though he tried as hard as he could to fight a monstrous surge of bereavement, he couldn't stop the tears.



Tami presented her with missed messages as soon as she got in to the office. "Mr. Stone wants to meet with you and his lawyer."

"Devlin?"

Tami said, "No. Stone senior. He'd like to know when you're available."

Kimmy shook her head. "Not this week. What else?"

Tami said, "Mr. Stone—I mean Devlin. He said he wants to see you at lunch."

"Okay. Where?"

Tami looked up, unsure. "He said you'd know where."



She waited till after noon just so Devlin would worry how he mattered. He was in his apartment, two cocktails ready.

She said, “I can’t, I have to go back to work.”

Devlin said, “Boss says you can take the afternoon off.”

Kimmy threw her bag to the couch and lifted her head, arched her back, showing great poise. There was a delightful unsureness Devlin tried to conceal from her. It showed in his posture and the ingratiating display of having prepared drinks for her arrival. The last time they'd been together, reality showed Devlin the error of his ways; Josh had launched a chair at him and there was nothing Devlin could do about it. Though Devlin would never admit it outright, his path, his machinations, had crumbled, had not only shown his mistakes to her, had shamed him. He wanted it to go without acknowledgment, wanted to maintain the facade, keep pretending they were enjoined in a scheme and that he had all the say. His father owned the company, after all.

Devlin brought both glasses over to the low table, set them down and sat beside her, looking at her. She said nothing.

He said, “Are you going to keep me in suspense?”

She looked his way, bored, uninspired. “About what?”

Devlin smirked, then assumed an expression like hers, leaning forward and retrieving his whisky drink, sipping it.

She said, “How’s your eye? You’re wearing makeup?”

Devlin set his drink down and sat back again, hooking his arm over the couch’s seat back, his hand near her face. He steadied his eyes on her.

“You’re toying with me,” he said.

She raised her chin, examined his face. “That’s a good match with your skin tone. I can still see you have a black eye, though.”

“Playful and bitchy,” Devlin said, then chuckled, looking across the room. His eyes returned to hers. “I think that means you have good news for me.”

She said, “Did you learn your lesson?”

“If I tell you I did, do I get a treat?”

“Tell me and find out,” she said.

Devlin rubbed his chin, breathing in a long, relaxed drag, scrutinizing her with narrowed eyes. “Why don’t you tell me what you want? Let me know how you would play this game?”

“You make it sound like it’s a mystery. Like I didn’t tell you to leave Josh to me.”

Devlin’s lips pursed, and he looked away.

She said to the side of his face, “Are you still fucking Amy?”

He regarded her like it was a crazy question. “No.”

“You’re playing games with me.”

“I’m not,” he said.

She said, “I see how you play games, and I see how they end up. If you play games with me, you will regret it.”

Devlin nodded, looking down, trying to maintain some masculine composure even though she treated him like a scolded child. “Amy might have fucked with Josh. Amy doesn’t like him.”

“Might have?”

He met her eyes. “No, she did fuck with him. I didn’t ask her to.”

“What did she do?”

“I mean, she’s in England. All she did was send him some texts.”

“For your benefit?”

“I did not ask her to do any of it.”

“Then why would she if you’re not fucking her?”

Devlin looked up, amused. “I’d say she would like for that to be the case.”

“That you were fucking her?”

“But I’m not,” he assured her.

“It’s hard when she’s so far away, I suppose.” She kept her eyes on him.

Devlin said, “Even when she’s here, it’s not like that. Not for a long, long time.”

“She can’t just stop thinking about you,” she said.

Devlin chuckled, raising an eyebrow. “Jealous?”

She didn’t smile. “Do I look jealous?”

In an obvious effort to appear more honest, Devlin shifted where he sat, speaking with his hands moving in earnest gestures. “I didn’t ask Amy to do anything. I talk to Amy, I tell Amy what’s going on, and Amy does crazy shit. She’s a loose cannon.”

“You had no idea? . . . I know you did. You’re just bragging to your old psycho friend who hates Josh, telling her all the crazy mean shit you’re doing.”

Devlin stared at her and she knew what he was thinking: he wasn't doing it alone.

She said, "You're a liability."

He nodded, shrugged a shoulder. "I won't talk to her anymore."

She shook her head, eyes narrowed. "How can I trust you? When you do something so stupid like talking to Amy, when you go and make moves behind my back? . . . How could I ever trust you?"

Devlin didn't know what to say, his mouth moving around, brow low and mean, wanting to fight back, defend himself, but they both knew he had nothing.

"They were supposed to work out, weren't they? Isn't that it? You expected different results?"

Now Devlin's eyebrows rose, and he looked at her with arrogant charm; still the methods of the spoiled schoolboy.

She said to him amused but plainly: "You failed."

Devlin rolled his eyes but couldn't deny it.

She said, "You think you're so great, and you don't realize I just watched you brag and grandstand your way into showing me the goofiest air ball in history. That's what it's called, right? Like not off the post or the rim, but like not even close."

Devlin backed away, unamused, smile gone. His eyes darted around the room, his brain parsing all the things he wanted to say and all the things he couldn't say and trying to find something.

She put on pressure. "Well?"

He said, "I think I hit the rim."

She chuckled and shook her head. "I'm not impressed by men who hit the rim."

Devlin's irritation was restrained, yet still plain to see. He fidgeted, assumed all the mannerisms of a man who didn't know when he was beat. She waited him out, waited for the tics and aggravation to pass, and he at last faced her, calmed, but eyes still dark and angry. He said, "So what now?"

She crossed her legs, leaned closer, the two of them half-facing on the couch. Her hand went on his knee, then stroked higher to mid-thigh. She had his attention.

She said, "You betrayed me. Caused me harm."

"I didn't betray you," he said, eyes turned down to her hand moving higher now.

"You caused me harm."

Devlin was silent, eyes still watching her hand as it rested at the seam of his thigh and hip, the heft of his large genitals pushing against her purlicue.

She said, "Do you deny it?"

"I . . . It's not what I wanted."

Her hand moved again, now going to his fly, searching out the tab and tugging it open in four tries. She slipped her hand inside and found his unshielded flesh growing turgid. She played fingers over his balls, found his cock head and teased it before taking his penis out and letting it hang from the open fly.

"But that's what happened," she said, petting his manhood and smiling at him.

CHAPTER 15

A RASH HAND IN EVIL HOUR

With Devlin's huge dick out now, the mood had changed. Devlin was primed and put into proper position. So she rose from the couch and he stayed seated, eyes tracking her. This was his realm; this was where he had always felt most comfortable and in charge. Devlin's mastery of sexual pleasure and dominance stood in for his missing capabilities, tried to hide his other shortcomings. She lifted a knee, reached under her skirt to take hold of her panties, then began the seductive removal of her underwear, drawing them down her shaved legs while Devlin's eyes burned on the action. She stepped out of the panties, stooped and retrieved them, holding them up so Devlin could see them.

Devlin said, "I recognize those."

"You played a trick on me with these," she said, winding them into a tight ball between two circling index fingers.

"I played a trick on Josh. Let's be real."

"Josh and I are one and the same and I told you that. I told you how we would handle it. That wasn't good enough for you."

"It's a matter of timing, Kimmy," he said, in a strangely confident tone, considering how he'd failed.

She snuffled a small laugh and approached him, Devlin with his fat dick hanging out of his fly and getting longer and fatter, Devlin parting his legs wider so she could admire his best feature. "Your timing was off," she said.

Devlin raised his face to hers, eyes sparkling in the midday sun streaming through the apartment's window. He put both arms up on the couch's back

in a pose of ultimate sexual mettle. She stooped and lifted his big gummy member, cradled her panties to support its heft before looping one end through a leg hole and cinching her panties mid-shaft, his penis squirming and rolling against his inner thigh. Devlin smiled, eyes turned down to watch her hands work with his manhood.

He looked up again. "How can my timing be off if you're here and I'm here and you tied your panties around my dick? Or should I say Josh's panties?"

"They're yours now, Devlin," she said, walking away.

Devlin tracked her, a slight measure of concern tightening his features, thinking she would leave him now, walk out the apartment door and never return. He said, "What do you mean?"

She slowed and smiled. "They're yours," she said. "I want you to put them on." She walked behind the couch, headed to the hall leading away from the foyer. Behind her, Devlin laughed.

"Yeah, right. Like that's going to happen," he said.

She ignored him and strutted down the hall toward the bedroom, heels clicking on hardwood.

Devlin followed, and by the time she turned at the bedroom, he was in the hall, walking while holding his dick, her panties still tied around the middle. She sat on the bed and waited for him. He arrived, walking in, his dick swinging with the panties still cinched. He paused and regarded her, then began undoing his cuff links. He said, "How is Josh today?"

"He's good," she said. "He's at work. I'm at work."

"Like nothing happened," Devlin said, slipping his cuff links into a pants pocket before unbuttoning his shirt.

"Something happened, Devlin," she said, "and you made my life much harder than I've ever wanted it."

He put his hands on his hips, shirt hanging open, hairy muscle showing, his half-hardened dick bowing outward, the tight cinch of her panties loosening its grip on his cock as the girth increased. “You’re here, Kimmy. You’re here in my apartment. You came to work. We’re still in this. Tell me we’re not and I’ll end it. I’ll find someone else.”

She snuffled again, scoffing at him. “You know you’d never find anyone to replace me. Not in a hundred years. You brought me to Stone to fuck with me and Josh, and I think you didn’t even comprehend what I could mean for you. You stumbled onto me by chance, out of sheer malevolence and boredom, looking to spice up your kinky sex life. Now you’ve got it all. Or at least you almost do.” She smiled, met his gaze, showed him what real confidence looked like.

His eyes showed uncertainty, then his features transformed into a mask of unperturbed charm. He said, “So what is it you want?”

She inhaled, looked up at the bedroom ceiling, thinking, or at least making an act of thinking. “A car.”

“A car? A company car? Yeah, no biggie. Sure.”

“I wear such fine clothes, you know, and then I get out of that Leaf.”

“Too sensible, yeah, I get it. We’ll get a lease.” He undid his belt.

She smiled wider. “And I want to see you in those panties.” Her eyes dropped to his big cock.

Devlin’s hands abandoned his belt buckle and fell to his sides. “I’m not putting on the fucking panties, Kimmy.”

She said, “What if I told you that you will put on those panties?”

He chuckled, then crossed his arms, muscles bulging through the shirt fabric. “Why don’t you strip down and we’ll get in bed, see if you can get them on me.”

She sighed, still smiling, stood up to him, face to face, then walked around behind him, saying, “Come over here with me,” and led him to a dresser against the far wall. Devlin followed and joined her in front of the huge mirror attached to the dresser’s frame. She looked at their reflection, then Devlin met her gaze in the mirror as well.

“We look good together,” she said. “It would be a shame if something broke us apart.”

Devlin said, “You’d miss out on a lot.”

She said, “I’d still have Josh, I’d still be a lawyer, and I’d still be smart and beautiful.”

“I was the one who told you that you were. I was the one who saw it.”

She looked down now, took his cock in hand and unhooked the panties and tossed them onto the dresser’s table. “Look in the mirror,” she said. “Face it for me.”

Devlin exhaled, shook his head, but faced the mirror. She slipped behind him, reached around and finished unbuckling his belt. She dropped his pants to his thighs. “Step out of those pants.”

Devlin pried off the loafers he wore in the house and stepped out of his pants, his bloated member bouncing off the insides of his thighs. He stood proud then, his body eclipsing hers in the reflection.

She said, “Do you see the woman behind the man?”

“Yeah,” he said, smiling to one side, eyes narrowing, seeing himself as the boss, the big man with the big dick and all the money and the woman who could make it happen, enamored of him and his power and his mighty sexuality.

“We’re a team,” she said.

He nodded, his macho pride dissolving into a more solemn look for a moment. He’d wanted to be the boss so bad he’d forgot his teammate.

Devlin needed to know they were still a team.

He said to her reflection, "I'm not wearing your panties."

She chuckled, kissed the back of his arm, then took his shirt collar and guided the shirt off his shoulders and down his arms. Now he was naked while she was clothed and standing in her heels. She circled her arms around his hips and hefted his penis and testicles in her hands, coddling, pleasuring, watching Devlin's eyes soften. His cock hardened further. She said, "What if I want to see how this thing looks in my satin?"

"It won't fit," he said. "Not like Josh's."

"He wore them to see you?"

Devlin smiled with meanness, watching her hand stroke him harder. His cock was still dry, no pre-cum yet, the sound of her skin on his skin harsh in the room's quiet. She held his cock upright, flattening it to his hard stomach, both of them admiring his size.

Devlin said, "Amy told him to. It wasn't me."

"But you liked that he wore them."

Devlin sighed, raising his eyebrows. "It's amazing what he'd do to get hard."

"You're the same," she said.

Devlin smirked, and she squeezed his hard cock right under his swollen glans, watching as a crystal bead formed in his urethral cup. She used it to polish his huge cock head and felt his knees sag, his weight shifting for a moment as she sent him into bliss. She kissed the muscles of his back and arm for a while as she pleased him, watching his hardness go shiny. He felt incredible in her hands, his erect penis one of the most exciting things she'd ever seen, and when she was sure he was ready, she reached with her other hand and plucked up her panties between two fingers. While one hand

stroked, the other caressed his hanging balls and the thick base of his cock with the soft satin of Josh's favorite underwear.

She asked Devlin now, "What did he look like in them?"

Devlin grunted, his cock flexing in her slippery grip, more lubricious pleasure streaming out of him. She stroked it over his head and felt him shudder.

"Weak," he said, his own voice a little thin at first, but then strengthening. "Pathetic. His little dick fit in your panties."

"Was he hard?"

"His little thing was rock hard. He loves wearing them."

She fought back a surge of bile, knowing this humiliation of the man she loved came from a poisonous snake a continent away, laughing at Josh, twisting him, thinking it brought her closer to Devlin. And maybe it did. The two of them were both malevolent creatures.

She gathered the material in her grip and used the satin to stroke his thick base, pulsing out more streams of his sexual lubricant, streams running over her shining knuckles as Devlin grew more and more aroused. "What would Josh think," she said, "seeing your huge dick in his favorite panties?"

Devlin's breaths were deep and long and lusty and this time he didn't deny her request right away, only chuckling like the matter was ridiculous—he would never wear the panties for her no matter what she said. But he would wear them. His eyes tracked her stroking hand's movements as he pictured what Josh would see: his long thick cock stretching her panties out, his shaft protruding above the waistband. It was a sexy sight she knew Devlin conjured right now, and she wanted to see it happen, too.

He sniggered now, eyes narrow, getting into the idea, the matter of him wearing a woman's panties no longer off the table. Voice low and masculine, he said, "What are you going to do for me?"

She said, “Give you your wildest, craziest fantasy. Something forbidden.”

He said, “What do you think that is?”

She rested her panties on top of his hard dick, holding it upright with her other hand, taking Devlin’s wrist and raising his hand to her tummy. She put her hand over his, her long fingers going between his, guiding the hand under her waistband and parting the halves of her tucked in dress shirt, finding the bare hot skin below her navel.

She watched his face transform from curiosity to bewilderment, then awe. His eyes met hers in their reflections, full of disbelief and questioning. Her hand stroked his iron cock, swollen to its largest size, his coronal ridge rippling under her fingers. She whispered, “I’m having your baby.”

AFTERWORD

The 14th book is already under way on my Patreon and on my Ream and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two!

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On my Patreon and on my Ream you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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